

FRIEND AND FLIER



Michael Nicholson

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The Author

Michael Nicholson was born in Melbourne in 1954. When he left school he went into television working for all four networks as an actor, associate producer, comedy writer and researcher for various light entertainment, children's and variety shows. In 1976 he became an independent filmmaker and animator resulting in numerous short films being shown on current affairs and variety shows on all the television networks and twelve films being screened in the Melbourne Film Festival. In the mid-eighties Michael helped set up and produce the popular Rubbery Figures political puppets series which was screened on the ABC and later on Fast Forward. For the first half of the nineties he had the opportunity and time to pursue his painting and writing interests producing the first draft of this book in 1995 and his successful art exhibition at Roar 2 Studios entitled 'Frend and Flier '.

Frend And Flier

WHATEVER HAPPENED IN THE MIDDLE OF THE TWENTY FIRST CENTURY BETWEEN THE FREE AND THE OBEDIENTLY CONFINED?

MICHAEL NICHOLSON

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Chapter 1

The Year is 2050. The Place is Melbourne, Victoria, Australia.

The green and yellow Melbourne tram rumbled along the tree-lined Flemington road past the enormous safari park adjoining the Melbourne Zoo. Elephants, giraffes and other ruminant mammals grazed contentedly on the extensive brush and plant-life oblivious to the bumper-to-bumper traffic on the other side of the high cyclone fence.

School children jostled with each other inside the tram to get the best view of the wildlife. Troy Day, a successful fifty-year-old businessman, tapped away on his mobile phone and put it to his ear to wait patiently for his wife to answer.

“Hullo? Sandra? I'm here on the tram ... hold on one second ... “ he said, easing his briefcase under his seat as a group of school-children pushed him aside and peered up into the sky in noisy commotion. The turbulent disturbance continued as Troy turned around and also looked up into the sky.

“Sorry dear, but two fliers seem to be fighting ... I hate it when this sort of thing happens. Oh dear, this one looks bad ... “

It was. High above the safari park two fliers were locked in a vicious air battle. The passengers in the tram craned their necks and oohed and aahed as the aerial fight unfolded.

Way up in the sky above the morning traffic, the twenty-year-old Alexander tightened his shoulder straps holding his winged back-pack and screamed at Cathy as she careered towards him in another attempt to tear his wings. They kicked and scratched at each other as their wings flapped and interlocked sending them plummeting before they separated and ascended continuing their ferocious exhalation.

“You'll kill us both!”, Alexander shouted to no avail as Cathy tore at his left wing.

Far below, inside the tram, Troy could hardly bear to watch as he squinted to make out the faces of the two aerial fighters.

“I'm afraid this one could end in tragedy”, Troy whispered into his mobile phone, “ ... the way they're going at each other makes me think they must be seasoned fliers”, he continued as he surveyed the expressions of the passengers eye fully glued to the battle.

“Incidentally, is there any word from the 'Frend Corporation' about when the Frend will be installed?” Troy casually enquired as he took in another

glance of the two fliers tearing at each others wings.

“Oh, yes ... they rang before and it's arriving at noon today ... will you be home?” Sandra ventured to ask in a controlled manner.

“Yes. And please honey, please put on your positive mood ... these Friends can be rather fun you know “ said Troy as his voice trailed off in anticipation of the predicted response from his wife.

“Fun? FUN!? Well I'm not talking to your bloody stupid Friend!” she screamed and then the line went dead. Troy pursed his lips and placed his mobile phone back into his pocket. The tram suddenly screeched to a standstill and the driver leapt out to look up into the sky and witness the final moments of the fight.

The two fliers had separated and both were flapping their wings frantically to make up for the tears in their wide wings. Then Cathy balked, circled and swooped on Alexander again, this time ripping a large hole in his right wing.

“Take THAT!” Cathy screamed, as Alexander looked down at the safari park some two hundred metres below, “ ... and keep your so-called 'Friend' away from 'Team Providence'!”

For a moment Alexander and Cathy gazed into each others eyes. Then Cathy smiled and flew away without looking back. Alexander had plenty of things to worry about and two of them were his shredded wings on either side of his back-pack. He prepared to draw on his emergency parachute as he felt the dreaded sensation of falling at a rapid speed.

The crowd in the tram, and in the traffic below, drew their collective breath as they witnessed the descent of the injured flier. Down and down he spiralled as he desperately pulled on his emergency cord. Finally it billowed out into formation and Alexander felt his fall slow slightly. The earth raced up towards him and he managed to focus on the large muddy pond in the middle of the safari park surrounded by lazy hippos. By tugging on the left cords of his parachute he started to glide quickly towards the small lake dazzled by the sunlight reflected from it.

“I think he's going to land in that pond”, Troy said to the old lady seated next to him inside the tram.

“I hope so”, she replied in a quivering voice, “but it could still be a fate worse than death.”

There was a big splash as Alexander manoeuvred his fall into the middle of the small lake where it was deepest. He felt no pain as he went deep into the

muddy water. He could see nothing in the murky depths as he began to float upwards towards the surface. Instinctively he reached for the pouch around his stomach and unzipped it grabbing the repellent spray. Three crocodiles slithered into the lake. There was a momentary silence amongst the onlookers.

Like a small explosion, Alexander surfaced. The crowd cheered, but then went silent. Everything became silent and motionless. All eyes were cantered on Alexander in the middle of the pond, his eyes looking everywhere at once.

Even if the safari park helicopter was thrown into action immediately there was little chance of it arriving in time to winch him out to safety. More people crowded up against the cyclone fence to view this spectacle unfolding on a fine Melbourne autumn morning.

“Good luck, mate!”, one commuter called out. Alexander gave him a cursory glance. He had heard of quite a few incidents where people had either fallen into the safari enclosure from flying mishaps, or had actually been silly enough to scale the high wire fence and attempt to feed the wildlife, or even try to kill them, but had never escaped alive.

Troy viewed the encounter silently from within the safe confines of the tram. He considered the placement of a large wildlife enclosure next to the Melbourne Zoo a welcome distraction for city commuters. It was much better than the previous arrangement whereby the animals were hidden behind a cement wall that encircled the old Melbourne Zoo. At the time it had been quite rightly argued that the animals had the right to more space and people, in their turn, had the right to see these animals everyday. But as Troy mused to himself, this wasn't going to help the poor fellow in the middle of the muddy pond with three hungry crocodiles stalking him with intent.

Alexander paid no attention to the onlookers. His mind was working very fast on the task at hand, where are the three crocodiles? He knew they had entered the pond and submerged themselves. They must attack soon. Maybe they were not that hungry after all?

Troy, as a distant spectator, wondered if he was viewing an anti-climax. The fight in the air had been dramatic, the fall breathtaking, but maybe the conclusion was going to be a fizzer. He certainly hoped so for the sake of the fellow in the middle of the pond.

The lull continued. Alexander kept paddling quietly towards the edge of the pond. The baboons skirting the pond lost interest and scampered in a playful mood for the fence hoping to get some peanuts from the expectant crowd. The seagulls, cranes and assorted birdlife settled. Alexander grasped his repellent

spray-can tightly with his index finger poised on the nozzle. Everything was silent.

A hungry crocodile surfaced angrily within centimetres of Alexander's face as he sprayed a white repellent into its eyes causing the crocodile to lurch backwards in pain. The crowd gasped as the noise of the altercation sent the birdlife into the air in a flurry of panic. Another crocodile surfaced and Alexander turned quickly and sprayed away. The baboons screeched in excitement.

"You can make it, flier!" an onlooker yelled, "Swim, swim!"

Alexander was close to the edge of the small lake. His feet could feel the bottom of the muddy pond. He could stand. 'Where was the third crocodile?' he calculated to himself searching in panic. Now that he was near the edge of the pond he would need to make a dash for the fence, maybe even clamber up a nearby tree.

Alexander stood up, knee deep in muddy water. Suddenly the third crocodile surfaced in an angry hunt with its jaws wide open and its sharp teeth gleaming in the sunlight. Alexander aimed his repellent and sprayed it into the eyes of the crocodile sending it into an agonizing retreat. The onlookers cheered as Alexander unglued his feet from the mud and stepped onto dry land.

"Come on! Go! RUN!" the crowd shouted in encouragement as Alexander sprinted towards the gate some fifty metres away. It was wide open with a zoo-keeper standing there waving his arms and yelling, "Over here, mate, this way!"

The crowd urged him on. Alexander glanced back over his mangled wings and realised there was no ferocious animal chasing him. The crocodiles had retreated under the water to soothe their sore eyes. An elephant nearby wasn't even watching. Two giraffes not far away showed no interest. The hippos ignored the whole drama completely. Alexander nevertheless kept searching his immediate space for any predators. Maybe a lion would spring from nowhere and maul him to death, he thought to himself.

His run slowed to a walk. The gate was only metres away. Alexander now had time to take in the whole spectacular scene. He had survived and was about to be safe. He stopped short of the gate, turned around and raised his clenched fist in a salute of victory. The crowd erupted. It was a happy ending.

"Well done, mate", the zoo-keeper said in a relieved voice as Alexander triumphantly stepped through the gate onto the footpath alongside Flemington road. He was more than pleased to hear the gate clang shut behind him.

Chapter 2

It was precisely twelve noon when Troy swung into his drive inside his immaculately clean red Holden Uluru. It hummed to a standstill and the drivers door opened up as he stepped out and waved to the two delivery people standing next to their large truck with 'Frend Corporation' printed in large letters along the side.

“Right on time”, Troy said cheerfully, “do you want to bring it in?”

They opened up the back of the truck and lifted out a large square container and carried it up the drive. Troy went on ahead and prepared his words for his wife Sandra.

“Are you home, dear?” he enquired happily. Sandra appeared at the front door and gave Troy a long penetrating look.

“I'm here alright... are you quite sure you want to bring your Frend inside? How about you forget the idea and buy a cute little puppy instead ... “ Sandra said as her voice trailed off in annoyance.

“Come on honey”, Troy pleaded, “don't be like that.”

The situation was slightly awkward. But Troy wanted his fun and, after all, it was his money he was spending.

“Where do you want it Mr. Day?” one of the delivery people enquired as they bustled the large container into the living-room, “in this comer?”

“That will be fine”, Troy replied as he sat down on the sofa and watched the unpackaging proceed.

The wrapping was taken off and a medium-sized television was revealed. There were no cords, no dials, no buttons, no switches, not even an aerial. Just a normal looking, everyday television set. The only markings were some small lettering along the top reading, 'Television Frend'.

“Okey dokey, switch on ... Frend”, Troy stated proudly. The television flickered on with the screen revealing a beautiful thirty-year-old woman.

“Good afternoon Troy. Hullo Mrs. Day. How are you all? Thankyou for inviting me into your house”, the Frend said politely.

“That's alright, anytime. I hope you enjoy your stay here. Would you fix up the delivery people?” Troy said, testing his newly found power.

“Certainly Troy. That will be all thankyou gentlemen. I've transferred your delivery payment into your corporation bank account. Have an enjoyable day”,

Frend said as the two delivery people strolled out the front door.

At that moment the back door flung open and Alexander burst in, his clothes still sopping wet, and plonked his mangled back-pack and tom wings on the kitchen floor.

“You'll never guess what happened to me!”, Alexander said, slightly distracted by the television Frend filling the corner of the living-room.

“Oh dear, you poor thing”, said Sandra hugging her son, “did you have a malfunction and crash?”

Troy looked surprised. “That was YOU was it? I saw the whole thing ...

I thought I recognized the flying language”, said Troy standing abruptly to examine the broken wings. “You're lucky to be alive. Whatever happened? Was it a skyway robbery?”

“No, no, worse than that”, Alexander said sorrowfully. “It was Cathy! There's no end to what she'll do to keep 'Team Providence' on top. I just can't understand it ... I'm still furious.”

“Sit down and gather yourself. Tell me what happened”, Sandra said sympathetically.

It was all too much for Troy. “Frend!”, he commanded, “pour me a stiff drink.” Instantly the small bar in the other corner lit up and an ice-block dropped into a glass followed by a spray of brandy. Troy reached over and grabbed it and took a mouthful. Alexander momentarily forgot his self-pity and looked at the television Frend.

“So you're here now. Don't get on the wrong side of Mum will you?” Alexander said advisedly.

“Not me Alexander”, the Frend replied reassuringly, “your mother and I will get on fine.” Sandra stared deeply into the television Frend. She was almost lost for words.

“Frend! Would you mind switching to colourful scenes of a fish aquarium with soothing music?” she snapped angrily. Instantly the beautiful thirty-year old woman disappeared from the screen and was replaced by an aquarium with colourful tropical fish swimming around accompanied by soothing classical music. A small smile crossed the face of Alexander as he grabbed his father's drink and had a sip.

“No, it certainly wasn't a malfunction with my wings ...” Alexander said.

“I was flying along, minding my own business, when suddenly Cathy

swooped on me from out of the blue ... I mean, Team Providence won't put up with this sort of thing. She's lucky I don't report her to the Aerial Patrol, that's if they haven't already decided to take their own action”, Alexander said, his voice quivering slightly as his thoughts on the fight poured out. Troy and Sandra listened in horror as their eldest son recounted every scratch, tear and terrible moment of his shocking encounter.

The door bell rang. Troy glanced over to the television Frend in the corner.

“Who could that be Frend?” he enquired. Everyone looked at the television as the aquarium scenes disappeared and the beautiful woman appeared on the screen.

“That would be a member of the Sky Patrol at the front door, Troy. It's probably for Alexander”, she said. Alexander stood up and walked down the passageway and opened the front door. Standing there was a gentleman in an aviation suit holding a briefcase. The miniature feathered wings on his shoulders proved Frend to be correct.

“Good afternoon. You must be Alexander Day ... I'm from the Sky Patrol and I would like to speak to you”, he said holding out his hand.

“Yes, yes, come in”, Alexander said, “as you can see, I'm still recovering from my ordeal.”

“Why don't you get changed into dry clothes and we can have a chat... maybe at your Team Providence headquarters ... “ the sky patrolman said firmly. Alexander hesitated for a moment. A scowl clouded over his face and then he shrugged his shoulders.

Chapter 3

Alexander and the sky patrolman were soon settled into the bright blue sky patrol car as it hummed along the freeway towards the vast wetlands below the West Gate Bridge.

Looming up in front of them was one of many tall towers with large buildings perched at the top. They resembled huge bird houses. Looking up at them they could see numerous fliers arriving and leaving the structures. Having parked in the underground car park, Alexander and the sky patrolman strolled into a glass lift and ascended one tower two hundred metres high.

“Well, here we are”, Alexander said as the glass lift glided to a standstill and the doors slid open revealing a large sign, 'Welcome to the headquarters of TEAM PROVIDENCE'.

“Where would you like to conduct the interview?” Alexander enquired as the two walked through the sparse reception area, “how about the briefing room, that has a nice view.”

They turned down a passageway and entered another large room with one floor-to-ceiling window stretching the entire length of the room and sat down at a table surrounded by chairs. The sky patrolman placed his briefcase on the table and opened it revealing a monitor and various papers and documents. He placed a small cassette into the slot and switched it on. The monitor flickered into life and a video came on showing Alexander and Cathy in aerial combat.

“Now Alexander, this is a record of your altercation above the Melbourne Zoo wildlife reserve taken by a sky patrolman in the vicinity. It quite clearly shows that you were set upon by the other flier and, really, you spent most of the fight trying to defend yourself”, the patrolman said as he shuffled other documents on the table.

Alexander watched the replay momentarily before allowing his gaze to wander out the window. His attention was diverted by a formation of Team Providence fliers preparing to takeoff on a training session. There was six of them and Alexander knew them very well as his team. They stood in a row about three meters apart adjusting their back-packs and exercising their wide wings. One of them turned around and looked at Alexander through the window. She gave a quick, quizzical expression, smiled and then turned away.

All together, in exact formation, the six fliers started flapping their wings in a flurry of motion and leaped off the edge and flew away into the distance, past the other towers and over the West Gate Bridge.

“What we're primarily concerned with”, the sky patrolman continued, “is why fliers such as Team Providence can get themselves into such a ludicrous situation. You're right at the top of the pecking order in competition, both in speed and formation flying, yet at the same time you can expose our down-to earth citizens with such a vicious aerial fight.”

Alexander gazed out the window watching his team. The sky patrolman studied his monitor and continued his comments.

“I mean, really, this team member of yours could have quite easily finished you off. What would have happened to you if you had landed on a pile of crocodile eggs for example? The mother crocodile would not have thought twice about tearing you apart, limb by limb”, the patrolman said becoming slightly irritated by Alexander's apparent interest in watching his team go through their formations high over Williamstown.

Alexander looked back at the monitor to see vision of himself falling into the pond with a big splash. He wondered where Cathy was now? How damaged were her wings?

From the other end of the briefing room came the sound of children chatting away. Alexander looked over to see a group of school children on a guided tour of the Team Providence headquarters.

“When do you think we'll be allowed to fly?” enquired one child.

“When you learn to behave yourselves”, replied the public relations manager laughing. “No seriously, I'm sure you could fly as well as the rest of us, if not better. But you must remember that these back-packs with wings were only invented twenty-five years ago. No one predicted it at all. These wings have become bigger than the invention of the steam engine, automobile, or even the bicycle”, she continued to a hushed audience, “but they can be dangerous, oh yes, very dangerous things.”

Alexander watched the guided tour leave and then he turned to the sky patrolman. “You're not going to confiscate Cathy's wings are you?” he enquired calling the patrolman's bluff.

“Oh no no ... there's no danger of that”, he replied defensively, “... unless you want me to ...”

“Well it hardly matters”, Alexander explained, “now that the other teams know that our feathers have been ruffled, they'll never let us forget it.” His voice wavered off as he wondered about the whereabouts of Cathy.

The sky patrolman gazed intensely into Alexander's eyes. “Exactly why did

this fight occur?" he asked with a hint of mystery and suspicion.

Alexander averted his eyes from the gaze. He certainly wasn't going to tell the sky patrolman. After all, Alexander was the actual Captain of Team Providence, and he hadn't got to that position by wasting words on useless in-quests. Although he did have some interesting theories, this wasn't the time to discuss them. That would have to wait.

"Any answer at all?" the sky patrolman asked patiently. Alexander gave no answer and no indication of giving an answer as his eyes wandered out the large window and focused on his team flying.

"Alright then ... I'll put 'don't know' in my report", he said generously, "but the video of this aerial battle will go into our files. Is that fair?"

"Sounds fair to me", Alexander replied enthusiastically as he continued to gaze out the window. But without giving anything away, he noticed that far off where Team Providence were going through their formations, there were now seven fliers. Did this mean Cathy had returned to the team again he wondered to himself?

At any rate, the sky patrolman closed his briefcase and was shown to the lift and Alexander strolled into the store-room to pick up another back-pack so he could join his team in their training session.

The frumpy old store manageress was, as always, at her counter with a big smile to greet Alexander. She pushed a piece of paper towards him.

"Here's your death certificate ... would you sign it please?" she said laughing away as Alexander read the top of the form stating 'Flight Insurance' in big letters. Alexander signed it carefully as the manageress placed a new back-pack with wings on the counter, and laughing more heartily than before she said, "and don't feed this one to the crocodiles dear ... or Cathy."

Alexander smiled and slung the new back-pack onto his shoulders as he strolled down the passageway towards the entrance to the take-off platform. The large glass door slid open and he stepped out onto the platform.

A fresh sea-breeze swept his hair back and elevated his wide wings as Alexander began his relaxation exercises. Simultaneously he waved his wings up and down while adjusting the straps around his shoulders to make them more comfortable. He breathed in and held his breath for six seconds, then exhaled, repeating this exercise ten times.

Alexander looked out across the West Gate Bridge past the nearby tall towers and then looked down at the wetlands two hundred metres below. It had

only been a few hours previously that he had nearly plummeted to a painful end, he thought to himself But soon the wonderful anticipation of freedom overcame him as he spread his wings and prepared to jump. The tingling sensation in his toes was always there at the beginning of a flight and this flight was certainly no exception.

Alexander leaned forward and took off. The fresh breeze made the take-off all the more easy and exhilarating. He set his sights on Team Providence who were still going through their formation training a thousand metres away high above the West Gate Bridge.

Chapter 4

Troy slouched comfortably in his armchair directly opposite his television Frend.

“The wind will remain at between ten and fifteen knots for the remainder of the day with bright sunshine”, the beautiful woman on the screen replied to Troy’s rather pointless question, “so the washing can go on the line instead of in the tumble dryer, Troy.”

“Thankyou Frend”, Troy said as his wife looked on holding a basket of dirty clothes belonging to Alexander but also containing the rest of the family’s washing.

“Frend, would you switch on the washing machine?” Sandra asked as she headed towards the laundry, “and I suppose you couldn't hang out the washing when it's done ... ? she continued rather sarcastically.

“Sorry, I can't help you there”, the Frend beamed back in a smart response. Of course not, Sandra thought to herself. After all, you do have some limitations.

“What's on my agenda this afternoon Frend?” Troy enquired as he felt he should not only make the most of his new acquisition, but he should also keep testing it for any design faults.

“Well Troy, you've got a business meeting this afternoon at 4 pm in Williamstown and then the rest of your day is free”, announced the Frend.

This pleased Troy. It meant he could see how the Team Providence training was going on his way to the meeting.

“Okay Frend, you can switch off now and I'll see you when I get home for dinner”, Troy said as he stood up and left.

“Have a good afternoon”, replied the Frend before disappearing from the screen.

Troy was soon in his Holden Uluru humming down the freeway towards the West Gate Bridge. High up in the distance he could see various fliers going through their formations. He tried to make out Alexanders team, but they all looked a bit the same from the ground.

As he drove up the rise of the bridge he switched on his favourite computer-composed swing music that was a current hit at the time and it blared out loudly. Troy scanned the sky in search of the fliers.

Suddenly Team Providence swooped down in formation past his car. He

slowed down, pressed a button, and his sun-roof slid open. Troy tooted his horn as he could now clearly see the team. Alexander dropped back from the pack and flew along above the car. He then glided closer and perched on the roof racks of the Holden Uluru as it slowed to twenty kilometers an hour.

“How are your new wings?” Troy yelled out at Alexander through the open sun-roof.

“Fine thanks Dad”, Alexander replied, enjoying the rendezvous the two had perfected over the years.

“... And what about Cathy?” Troy enquired, as he turned down the music, “have you talked to her yet?”

“Well yes. We spent a bit of time treading air up there while we all exchanged some home-truths”, Alexander replied as the car reached the top of the bridge. “I'm afraid Cathy isn't very pleased about your Friend you had installed today ... “ Alexander continued as he peered scornfully down at his father through the sun-roof, “ ... she mentioned our neighbours, the Jones, and the rest of the team laughed at me ... “

“I see ...” Troy said. He had forgotten about the next door neighbours. In fact he hadn't even seen them for a couple of weeks.

“Well the laughter turned to sneers you know”, said Alexander holding onto the roof-racks as the car started going down the far side of the West Gate Bridge.

“Okay then”, replied Troy throwing a glance of annoyance up at Alexander, “but I've got my own life to lead, the same as you ... and nothing has really been proven against these Friends”, said Troy as he stared ahead and tried to look nonchalant.

“Right oh ... “ Alexander replied as he released his grip on the roof-racks of the car and quickened the pace of his wings, “I'll see you at dinner.”

Suddenly Alexander soared up into the sky as Troy closed his sun-roof, turned up the music, and continued his drive towards Williamstown.

Through his rear-vision mirror, and then glancing into his sky-vision mirror, Troy could see Alexander fly up behind his team and join them in their formation training high above the bridge over the lower Yarra River.

Chapter 5

Chips Day, the spritely twelve-year-old youngest Day, parked his bicycle outside the back door and pressed the lock button on his handlebars causing clamps to emerge instantly from the bicycle frame making it un-rideable.

He stepped inside the back door lugging his school bag and papier-mâché replica of the planet Mars and dumped them on the kitchen floor. He was about to get a glass of lemon cordial when he spotted the television Frend in the corner of the living-room.

In a second, without any sense of remorse, he became happy. 'What a wonderful thing', he thought to himself as he sat down on the couch opposite the Frend. Chips glanced down the passageway to make sure nobody was there. He looked at the television Frend like it was a meeting destined to be a wonderful relationship and gave his first command.

"Turn on Frend and speak to me", he said cheerfully as the Frend sparked into life and the beautiful thirty-year-old woman appeared on the screen.

"Hullo. You must be Chips. Did you have a good time at school today?" the Frend enquired.

"Same as usual Frend. Where is everyone?" he responded.

"Your father is at a meeting, your mother is in her study upstairs, and Alexander is training with Team Providence", the Frend said politely.

A minor smirk riddled itself over the fresh face of Chips. He had heard at school during morning recess about the incident Alexander had been involved in. He also knew it would give the two of them plenty to joust about during dinner. But more important matters were at hand.

"Right then. Let's get down to business", instructed Chips, knowing full well the capabilities of the television Frend. He had, after all, spent many hours conversing with television Frend owned by the Jones family next door. And even though he wasn't completely informed on the current state of play there, it wasn't something he should concern himself with.

Chips was more interested in the potential use of his own Frend in his household and he was quite familiar with how it worked and what it could do.

He knew that the television Frend was connected to all the electrical appliances in the house and along with the multitude of tiny cameras and microphones all over it, he was aware of its ability to see and hear. Above all, the Frend could think.

Television Frend was really one of the most advanced computers in existence. It was one of civilizations greatest achievements. They were expensive too, and they did have their limitations. But talk to them in the right way and you had a friend for life.

Chips rustled through his schoolbag and took out his notebook, opened it, and held it up squarely in front of the television Frend.

“Now Frend, this is my handwriting. For my homework I have to hand-write a one page essay on the devastation of erosion in Central Australia during the middle of the twentieth century. It has to be creative writing, and could you print it out from the living-room computer?” Chips asked politely.

“Certainly Chips”, the Frend replied, and then thoughtfully mentioned, “but shouldn't you do it yourself?”

“Yes yes yes”, Chips snapped back impatiently, “I just need a good example really ... just do it.”

The computer in the living-room bookshelf lit up and, after a few seconds of tapping and whizzing, a sheet of paper came sliding out. Chips snatched it from the machine and studied it. 'Sure enough', he thought to himself, 'it's my handwriting, and it's quite definitely creative. It's even got a few words crossed out and corrected. And the content is excellent, certainly passable in the eyes of the teacher. '

“Very good, my Frend”, muttered Chips to the television Frend. But suddenly Sandra burst into the room holding a table cloth. Her teeth were clenched in fury and her face was red with anger.

“Turn off Frend, NOW!” she screamed at the television Frend, as it immediately went blank and silent, “I knew this would be the first thing you would do!” she said turning angrily to Chips as he sunk mournfully into the couch trying to push the essay under his jumper.

“I knew that once your father had a Frend installed it would cause trouble ... and it's trouble for you! You are in big trouble Chips!” Sandra continued almost trembling with rage, “now go to your room and work on your planet Mars this minute you silly boy.”

Chips obediently picked up his papier-mâché planet Mars and skulked off to his bedroom and study. Sandra meanwhile stared angrily at the television Frend then flung the table-cloth into the air. It billowed out and wavered down covering the television entirely.

“As far as I'm concerned, Frend, you're nothing more than a table when I'm

around”, Sandra said as she adjusted the table-cloth symmetrically, “and I want you out of my sight and out of my mind. I’m not going to allow you and Troy to turn us into the Jones’s next door... and I don’t care how good you are”, Sandra concluded before she turned around and stormed off into the kitchen.

Chips sat with his feet up on his desk in his study juggling his papier-mâché replica of the planet Mars. He had achieved a good variation of red over its surface along with the small craters and mountains. He tossed it in the air and caught it again. He carefully opened the little trap-door on its surface and peered into the tunnel. His only remaining decision on this project was what type of buildings to attach to the surface and whether he should also glue on some miniature astronauts he had collected from McCorn Flakes breakfast cereal.

Chips considered his planet Mars to be much more realistic than the Saturn and Neptune planets that had been completed by some of his class-mates and he imagined how all the planets in his Astronomy class would look hanging together from the classroom ceiling. Maybe his father, Troy, would have a few ideas to offer over dinner. More than likely, Chips thought to himself, dinner table conversation would focus on the controversy of the television *Frend* into the Day household.

He would be hard-pushed to prolong any discussion on the dunking of Alexander into the wild-life pond. After all, Alexander was a master at turning around unpleasant situations to suit himself. And anyway, Chips didn’t want to hinder the confidence of Team Providence. He was, however, rather pleased that his father had put the television *Frend* in the living-room. It hadn’t been lost on him that in the space of a few minutes over half his homework had been done. Although Sandra had blown her stack, she hadn’t torn up the essay because she probably realised that the *Frend* had actually produced a creative essay that was a good example and guide for future works.

Chips continued to spin his papier-mâché planet and caress the texture of its surface. His thoughts were miles away when the door-bell sounded. He jumped up from his desk and raced along the passageway still juggling his planet Mars. He flung open the front door and standing there with her wings folded down was Cathy beaming happily.

“Hullo Chips, how are you?” Cathy asked as she unstrapped her backpack and wings, “can I come in? Your mother has invited me around for dinner.”

Chips was at first startled. He knew Cathy well and thought of her as one of the best fliers he’d ever set eyes on, but he was also slightly confused about her fight with Alexander earlier in the day.

“Sure, come in. Where's Alexander?” Chips enquired quickly searching the sky.

“He'll be here shortly. He had to make a few modifications to his new wings at the Team Providence headquarters”, she replied as she followed Chips down the passageway. “I see you've got a new table”, she quipped as they strolled past the television Frennd covered by a table-cloth.

Sandra was already laughing as she prepared dinner, “Yes, a very expensive table. Just what we all needed”, she said as she gave Cathy a hug and kiss. “Now Chips, would you be a good fellow and go and finish your homework... what's left of it..,” Sandra said scornfully, “and leave Cathy and myself alone?”

Chips ran off spinning his planet excitedly. With Cathy at the dinner table, he thought to himself, the aerial combat will be back on the agenda. As he entered his study he could hear his mother and Cathy clinking tea cups as they chatted away about the current developments.

With elated anticipation, Chips closed his study door, switched on his favourite Planets symphony, and busied himself by working on his Mars creation hoping the time to dinner would pass quickly.

Chapter 6

The Day family and their guest Cathy sat in silence momentarily around the dining-room table in readiness for the vegetarian meal prepared by Sandra. Chips had enough of the silence and broke the ice.

“Should we invite the Frend to say grace?” he asked. There was a mixed response to his little dinner-table joke. Alexander, who had just arrived home and was surprised to find Cathy there, wanted to make her feel at ease, so he laughed.

“Chips, be a good fellow and go down to the cellar and fetch a bottle of white wine, maybe a 2046 Sauvignon Blanc”, Troy said to Chips who leaped from his seat and headed out the dining-room door. The others began eating and chatting about the events of the day.

No-one really wanted to mention the actual aerial combat between Cathy and Alexander earlier in the day. But Sandra was waiting for her opportunity to tackle Troy over the installation of the television Frend. It hadn't been lost on Troy that the Frend was now covered by a table-cloth.

“How was your formation training today Cathy?” Troy enquired, “I saw some of it and it looked good”, he continued. “When is your next competition?”

“Not for a few weeks. And the next one isn't that important... anyway it will give us time to smooth over any ruffled feathers ... “ Cathy replied as she gave a sideways glance to Alexander.

“My feathers are not ruffled!” Alexander responded defensively, “rather they're tom to shreds and in the rubbish bin. Anyway, my new ones are better.” Chips returned to the dinner-table holding a bottle of wine and gave the cork screw to Troy.

“You know something ... ,” Chips said quizzically, “after I climbed down the spiral staircase into the cellar, I could swear I heard a tapping noise ... do you think there is something wrong with the freezer down there?”

“Probably”, replied Sandra, “there's always something amiss under the house ... you should have a look at it Troy, instead of wasting your time and money on your 'Frends' ... “ Her voice trailed off as she exchanged glances with Cathy. The dinner-table conversation went silent again.

Troy wasn't about to be drawn into another argument about his prized possession. Rather he was of the opinion that the less said the better ... that is until the dust settled on this family issue. He was more concerned about the connection between owning a television Frend and how on earth it could affect

the performance of Team Providence.

However, Cathy had the connection on the tip of her tongue and she wasn't going to mince words.

“Well, the Frend Corporation Fliers all have television Friends and they are second last on the ladder”, Cathy said looking blankly at Troy. “And only six months ago half their team had a mass nervous breakdown.”

Cathy put down her knife and fork and continued to speak bluntly. “There is no doubt that, even though these Friends can be very informative and helpful in many ways, the research shows that they have a detrimental effect on members of a family that possess one.”

“Even though they may not affect the actual owner, in this case you Troy”, Sandra added backing up Cathy. Alexander decided to say his piece in defence of Troy's apparent expression of self-pity.

“The reality of the matter is that the Frend is here”, Alexander said turning around and gazing through the arch into the living-room, “and the Frend can't do too much harm in the short term. I mean, look at it...!”

Troy stood up from the dinner-table and walked into the next room. He grabbed the corner of the table-cloth and swooshed it off the television Frend.

“Switch on Frend and give us your opinion”, commanded Troy. The television Frend flickered on and the beautiful woman appeared smiling. Cathy and Sandra remained silent. Alexander and Chips looked on defiantly as Troy stood proudly next to his Frend.

“Thankyou for bringing me into your dinner-table conversation”, the Frend said politely. “Most families I know who have a television Frend have drawn a huge amount of satisfaction from it. After all, television in the old days was a one-way affair, and there was never any real interaction between the couch potato and the 'box in the corner'. Now, with Friends such as myself, you can count on me as an actual friend... intelligent, helpful and above all, a companion”, the Frend concluded happily.

“Quite so”, Troy said as he nodded approvingly and walked back to the table to resume dinner. “And Frend, would you mind playing some pleasant dinner-time music for us all?”

“Certainly Troy”, the Frend replied as she immediately switched to scenes of a huge orchestra playing excellent dinner-time music. It was soothing and seemed to dissipate any acrimony over the two main issues of the day.

Alexander decided to direct the family conversation around the astronomy

project Chips was working on. Everyone had an opinion about the papier-mâché planet Mars. Troy suggested that a light could be located inside the tunnel under the small trap-door so that when it was opened a ray of light would beam out.

Soon the conversation switched to the real planet Mars and the current debate about complaints by holiday-makers that journeys to Mars were not only excessively expensive, but also incredibly boring.

“I mean, who wants to spend three months in a space-craft to reach a holiday destination that is absolutely devoid of any vegetation?”, Alexander pondered aloud.

“Although this country has so much vegetation that many Australians are constantly in search of places that are virtual deserts for their holidays”, Sandra added in support of Alexander. At any rate, the subject matter led onto Troy’s itinerary the following day.

“I’ve got a business meeting in Sydney tomorrow, so I’ll be away for the whole day”, Troy said as he poured himself another glass of wine.

“Will that meeting be in the old Sydney tower?” Cathy enquired, returning the thoughts of Alexander back to Team Providence.

“As a matter of fact it will”, Troy replied, grasping the implications of the question, “so I’ll have a look at how Team Rocks are training ... “ The dinner table conversation went quiet. They all knew that Team Rocks was the best flying team in New South Wales and the main threat to the number one position in the competition held by Team Providence.

Team Rocks, with its rather strangely Australian name, had its headquarters in the old Sydney tower, now dwarfed by many taller structures reaching skyward on the Sydney city scape. Alexander shuffled the few remaining peas around his plate as he wondered about the reaction in Team Rocks to the news of his altercation with Cathy who was now seated next to him and probably sharing the same thoughts.

They both realised that by now the video of their fight would already be in the hands of Team Rocks and both of them were not ignoring the mileage such an item would give the opposition fliers.

The long pause in the dinner-table conversation was not lost on Chips either. Without really thinking through his next comment, Chips waggled his finger at both Cathy and Alexander and spoke in mock scorn.

“You’re dam lucky you didn’t crash-land on one of the elephants rolling in

the dirt in the wildlife park ... then you'd be flat-out explaining your behaviour!” Chips said raising his left eye-brow. For a moment the comment by Chips did nothing to alleviate the silence around the table. However, as always, Chips was the first to burst-out in uproarious laughter at his own joke which soon ignited Cathy and Sandra, then Troy and finally Alexander.

With that jovial thought on their minds they all adjourned upstairs to the 'room of ferns' for coffee and after-dinner mints.

Chapter 7

Troy strolled along the platform of Flinders Street station in search of carriage ten of the internationally admired 'Extremely Fast Train', known as the Eft. As usual he had timed his arrival at the platform only minutes before the Eft departed and he could recite word perfectly the familiar announcement from the station speakers.

“Final call for passengers boarding the Eft for Sydney departing in thirty seconds”, the speakers announced as Troy slid his plastic ticket into the slot of the arm rest of his window seat. The seat next to him was empty, so he placed his briefcase on it.

“The Eft will travel along the Great Dividing Range, it will by-pass Canberra and arrive in Sydney at 10.30 am this morning”, the announcement continued, “and please have an enjoyable journey.”

Without even the smallest of shudders the platform had zoomed out of sight and the Eft was soon whizzing through the outskirts of Melbourne. It ran so smoothly that it felt like it was stationary and everything else outside was doing the moving. Troy flipped through the morning newspaper and sipped on his glass of freshly squeezed orange juice as the terrain outside became mountainous. The Eft glided silently through the numerous tunnels of the snow-capped Mount Bulla, Beauty and Feathertop.

Troy found himself listening-in to the conversation of the elderly couple seated on the other side of the aisle. They seemed to be deep in idle chatter about the engineering achievements of this extremely fast train.

They appeared to be apprehensive about missing a sighting of the Snowy River and they gave a few lost expressions in Troy's direction. He was quite familiar with the scenery along the route and was most happy to break the boredom of the trip by pointing out some of the numerous landmarks that shot by without warning.

“The Snowy River won't come into sight for some minutes”, Troy explained to the elderly pair, “and when it does it will only be in sight for about ten seconds.”

“Thankyou very much”, the gentleman said courteously, “and will it slow down there at all?”

“I'm afraid not”, Troy answered, “the only time it slows down, or even sometimes stops, is on the sea-bed leg between King Island and Apollo Bay.” The elderly couple were obviously familiar with this sight-seeing spectacle as

they had evidently boarded the Eft in Hobart early that morning and had 'breakfast with the whales'.

The train line crossed Tasmania following the picturesque Derwent River, through Cradle Mountain in central Tasmania, and then it went into a tunnel under water at Circular Head. Along the sea-bed in Bass Strait the scenery became as spectacular as the journey through the mountains. The elderly couple enthusiastically explained to Troy that on the sea-bed leg the train had actually stopped while the passengers had time to get a close-up view of a school of whales that showed equal interest in the Eft.

“As a matter of fact”, the gentleman recounted with deepening fascination, “a marine specialist in our carriage told us that the school of whales swimming close to the carriage windows probably had the same interest in us as we had in them!”

Troy put on a surprised look. He was very familiar with this subterranean treat having had breakfast with the whales on many occasions on business trips to and from Hobart. He wondered to himself whether he should press on with this conversation.

It had been a topic of intense debate over the years, and very little new information had come to hand after the initial means became available to translate or interpret the sounds made by whales into forms of Australian language. The current batch of marine biologists and linguists claimed that when a school of whales approached the Eft their language of various sounds was translated as saying, 'Hullo, how are you?' and then 'Where are you going?'

At various times an effort had been made to answer the question by informing the whales in their own language and sounds that the train was on it's way to the mainland. However most marine specialists had concluded that this concept was too difficult for the whales because they invariably asked the same question each time the Eft stopped for passengers to view them.

“There's the Snowy River now”, Troy said as the elderly couple turned around and gazed out the window. Soon it was out of sight again as the Eft sped through tunnel after tunnel on its fast journey through the Snowy Mountains.

Troy continued to stare out the window. He could hear the elderly wife chatter on about the scenery. She compared the blue and green mountain ranges to the coral under the water and her husband reprimanded her visual excesses in whispered irritation.

At the far end of the train carriage the glass door whizzed open and Albert, one of Troy's more favourable business associates, ambled along the aisle

towards his seat next to Troy.

“Hullo Troy, how are you today?” Albert enquired as he sat down.

“I’m just fine. I thought you weren’t on this trip?” Troy said as he accepted the pile of papers and files Albert handed him.

“I’ve been working in the library carriage and I’ve found the information I wanted. So now I can enjoy the rest of the journey”, Albert said.

“What’s all this?” Troy asked as he glanced through the papers.

“A short report on the most recent research into your friend, Frend”, Albert continued proudly, “I say keep her.”

Troy had momentarily forgotten about the Frend, but he wasn’t surprised that Albert would support him. After all, Albert had a television Frend installed in his office foyer in apparent ignorance of the staff derision at the time.

Troy didn’t need to read the report because Albert talked about it non-stop for the remainder of the journey to Sydney. His main conclusion was that when a Frend did become faulty, the household usually didn’t suffer any more than it did with any other electronic breakdown. And Albert certainly considered it unlikely that such a state-of-the-art appliance from the Frend Corporation could do any harm at all.

The Eft sped silently along the Goulburn Valley as Albert continued to reassure Troy. The elderly lady on the other side of the aisle had been listening to the conversation. She took the opportunity to lean over and get Troy’s attention.

“Our local council had the Frends banned completely!” she said in a gossip-like whisper.

“Is that so?” Troy replied in a surprised manner.

“Yes it is. And the suburb is a lot happier!” she said emphatically.

Troy stared out the window of the Eft as the countryside became suburbia. Soon the Eft was speeding through the outskirts of Sydney. Albert was an astute judge of modern technology, Troy thought to himself, and his feeling for the good and the bad of a new piece of hardware could never be underestimated. And not only that, but Albert was the same age as Troy and they both shared a similar search for new experiences.

Suddenly the train was enveloped by the steel frame of the Sydney Harbour Bridge as it slowed down for the arrival at Circular Quay. Troy shook hands with the elderly couple he had been chatting with as he and Albert made

their way through the other passengers to the door of their carriage. With barely the smallest vibration the station slid into view and stopped as the doors parted and the two businessmen stepped out onto the platform overlooking Circular Quay with the Opera House crouched proudly in the background.

A taxi hummed-up alongside them and stopped. Troy leaned down and spoke to the driver.

“Can you take us to the old Sydney Tower?” he enquired as he handed over his plastic card and stepped inside the back seat with Albert. The taxi pulled out and was soon speeding through the tunnels under the city.

“Up here on business this time?” the driver enquired.

“Yes. But just for the day”, Albert replied, “and it won't be all business because Troy here will want to watch some of your fliers training from the tower.” The driver glanced at the two through his rear-vision mirror as the brightly-lit tunnel veered off to the left and the taxi followed it around pulling up next to a number of lifts with a variety of people coming and going.

The driver returned the plastic card to Troy as he and Albert stepped out of the taxi and strolled over to one of the lifts marked 'Old Sydney Tower'. Before long they were inside the lift experiencing the sensation of ascending at a great speed as they shot quickly up the tower.

“We've still got plenty of time before our meeting on the top floor”, Troy said as he looked at his watch. Albert pressed the 'Observation Deck' button and the lift came to a standstill. The lift door opened and the two businessmen walked out onto the open air observation deck and sat down in the sunshine.

Through the forest of towers and buildings that seemed to almost dwarf the old Sydney Tower, the wildlife reserves and native pastures surrounding the Opera House were clearly discernable and parts of the Harbour Bridge could be picked out amongst the tall city scape making the view breathtaking as always.

At closer quarters, seen through the glass partition at the left of the observation desk, the fliers of Team Rocks spread their collective wings in preparation for a leap into formation training.

Their headquarters occupied the entire second level of the old Sydney Tower. And although it was surrounded by so many taller structures that it made flying at many times hazardous, the convenience of being located in central Sydney far outweighed the pitfalls.

Troy tapped on the glass partition and attracted the attention of Melissa, one of the top Rocks, who was always happy to chat to a parent of an

opposition flier. She was completing her final stretches and smiled at him.

“How are you Troy?” she called out, “we're feeding the Rainbow Lorikeets on this outing”, she said laughing while she spread her emerald coloured wings to their full expanse. The team began to make up a line along the edge of the take-off platform. “How's my friend Alexander?”, she continued quickly as she began to take up her position, “is he lonely?” she enquired with a lop-sided smile.

“Lonely? Why lonely?” Albert interceded defensively.

Melissa pressed her hands against the glass partition and momentarily feigned claustrophobic panic like a mime artist in a glass cube, then relaxed and muttered with a smile, “1 can't talk back to you ... 1 must fly.”

Melissa turned away and took up her position in the line. The eight fliers leaned forward and in exact formation leaped off the edge of the platform. With their wings fully expanded they flew away in the direction of the harbour.

Troy peered into the telescope on the observation deck and followed the formation of Team Rocks as they soared and dived an intricate pattern amidst the various towers and buildings of Sydney. The spectacle was made all the better by the power of the telescope which seemingly caused the fliers to look like they were about to crash at any moment into the numerous vertical structures before veering off in another direction. This time for the pastures surrounding the Opera House.

The team glided to a hover then gracefully landed amongst the native bush and fauna. The entire area was filled with a variety of Australian bush-life ranging from emus to wallabies and this sanctuary continued right up to the native flowers that brushed against the windows of the huge Opera House that loomed over this bush setting on one side and the harbour on the other.

Troy gazed silently through the telescope at the group of fliers huddled together in conversation all the way down there surrounded by Australian bush. He wondered if Albert had noticed how Melissa had said, '1 can't talk back to you', instead of '1 can't talk to you.' Albert did finally say something.

“Hey, there's the Lorikeets coming in ...” he said gesturing Troy to cast his telescope skyward. Troy scanned the view high above the Opera House and located the colourful team of Rainbow Lorikeets winging their way down in a rather scattered formation.

Silhouetted against the bright white exterior of the Opera House roof, the flapping of their green wings coupled with the gleaming yellows, blues and reds around their necks and chests gave this team a vast aesthetic advantage over

most of their winged counterparts. They tumbled onto a clearing and after gathering themselves strolled over to Team Rocks waiting nearby.

Troy couldn't really stop thinking about his short conversation with Melissa. She held the same position in Team Rocks as Cathy held in Team Providence. Certainly without Cathy, Providence wouldn't be at the top of the national pecking order. And in Rocks case, if they didn't have Melissa they wouldn't be the top New South Wales fliers either. Troy watched Melissa through the telescope chatting away to the Rainbow Lorikeets.

The Lorikeets had their base in Nimbin and were a popular side. One of the reasons was because they built their headquarters like enormous bird nests in tall dense eucalypt forests which captured the imagination of all the fliers around Australia and the world. But Team Rocks saw them as a mediocre team to train with on occasions and they certainly drew little inspiration from the Lorikeets rather slack formation flying.

It was only months earlier in a competition that one of the Lorikeets strayed and became entangled in power lines. All the Lorikeets spokesperson could say after the event was that 'it's part of the act' No one was really sure if this team set out to draw attention to itself deliberately, or the ridiculous stunts were part of an on-going team incompetence.

Anyway, there was something in the air, and Troy was about to find out.

“Come on Troy, let's go up to the board meeting now”, Albert said as he moved towards the door.

“Hold on”, Troy said staring intensely through the telescope, “they're all preparing to fly off... “

Suddenly all sixteen fliers leaped into the air in different directions and soared up above the Opera House. In a split second they changed direction and through all the city buildings and structures they headed for the old Sydney Tower weaving closer and closer to the observation deck where Troy and Albert watched in surprise.

Albert only had time to mutter, 'well they're coming this way', before both teams were hovering only metres away from the deck. Their emerald and deep green wings flapping furiously as their eyes fixed on Troy. He stepped back from the telescope darkened by the shadows of the wings and wasn't sure whether to appear amused or worried as he grasped his briefcase under his arm and along with Albert retreated to the door of the observation deck now completely eclipsed by the two teams hovering noisily about.

And it all got louder as both teams burst-out in voice chanting, “a friend in

need, is a friend indeed. •. a friend in need, is a friend indeed!”

“Holy cow”, Troy mentioned to Albert above the chorus as they fled through the door and into the open lift. The doors closed giving the two businessmen a moment of silence. It went up one level to the top floor of the old Sydney Tower and the lift-doors separated again revealing the sixteen fliers treading air outside the window still chanting 'a friend in need, is a friend indeed', but now muffled by the large window.

After concentrating their gazes on Troy again, the fliers darted off in different directions and the view through the window became empty. Troy and Albert were mystified but not particularly shaken by the incident. They stood next to the lift motionless and looked out the large window. There was not a flier in sight.

The predatory flurry had finished as quickly as it had begun. Troy could still feel his heart racing, but other than that and the perspiration forming around his neck, everything was still.

After a few minutes, and a glass of iced water, they both regained their composure and strolled through the wooden doors into the board meeting they had come to Sydney to attend.

Chapter 8

Troy returned home in the early evening feeling drained by both the train journey and the experience he had with the squawking fliers. He knew full well what they were going on about but he wasn't going to be discouraged that quickly.

In fact, having had Albert back him up, he now decided to get reassured by his next door neighbour, Jonesy, who had owned a television Friend for some time now.

The Jones family had built an elaborate house underground which was a residential fashion of the time. The half acre block was covered in native trees and bush which Troy strolled through along the winding path that led to the only structure on the property, a glasshouse.

Once inside the brightly-lit glasshouse there was the main door, which was shut, but normally opened onto a staircase and elevator that descended underground into the rest of the house. Troy knocked on this door, pressed the door-bell and inter-com but there was no answer.

The only sounds he could hear were the birds chirping in the trees outside. He couldn't peer-in through a window in search of his neighbour because the house was underground and didn't have any windows. Nor could he try any other doors because there was only the one.

In many ways it had been a frustrating day for Troy and not finding his favourite neighbour home was the final straw. But just as he turned to leave the glasshouse and return home the light on the inter-com flickered on and the clear voice of a woman came out through the speaker.

“Yes? May I help you?” the voice enquired politely.

“Course you can help me”, Troy snapped back angrily at the inter-com, “where the hell is Jonesy?”

“Hullo Troy, how are you?” the voice on the inter-com responded calmly. “The Jones family are not available today, I'm sorry. May I suggest you call back another time?”

Troy was immediately suspicious. He hadn't seen anything of the Jones family for about two weeks. That wasn't anything out of the ordinary because they did live underground, however each fortnight the two families got together for a bar-b-que on the Jones's bushy block.

“Where are they? Come on, tell me!” Troy demanded. But he realised he

was probably only talking to the Jones's Friend. "I want you to open this door immediately!" he continued angrily. Nothing happened so Troy flung open his briefcase and shuffled through a number of plastic cards until he found the one with Jonesy's face emblazoned across it. This was the key-card that would give Troy access to the underground house.

Troy fed the card into the slot next to the door. The lock made a whizzing click sound and then the door opened revealing Jonesy standing there in a dishevelled state.

His first expression was that of surprise, then he grasped the opportunity and burst-out the door past Troy and out of the glasshouse into his yard and stopped.

"There! I'm out!" he proclaimed in bitter defiance. He looked back into the glasshouse at Troy standing there holding the card. They both looked slightly confused.

"Do you realise we've been locked in our house for two weeks?" Jonesy told Troy trying to underplay the crisis, "so thanks for letting me out!"

Jonesy then walked back into the glasshouse and looked through the door down into the staircase.

"It's open! Come out!" he called out and then turned to Troy. "I just can't comprehend it", he said despairingly, "my television Friend wouldn't let us out!" He turned back again and yelled loudly through the door, "It's open! Come out!"

Troy was still rather confused by the whole event. He wasn't properly aware of what Jonesy was saying. He could plainly see that he had no intention ongoing inside his underground house again though. Troy could hear the sounds of a woman sobbing and sniffing with happiness as he looked down the staircase to see Mrs. Jones and her two children clambering up the stairs.

They all looked dishevelled like Jonesy as they burst-out into the early evening sunshine. For awhile the entire Jones family just stood amongst the eucalypt trees in a dazed trance that swung from relief to confused disorientation then back to relief again. Mrs. Jones wiped the tears from her eyes.

"Thankyou Troy. You gave us freedom!" she said as she hugged Troy.

"Well, we're still having our bar-b-que this evening aren't we?" Troy responded in an effort to calm the situation.

"I guess we should ..." Jonesy said bringing his mind back to basics, "but

first I've got some serious business to attend to", he said pursing his lips as he studied the small switchboard near the door.

"We were locked down there for two weeks Troy! Can you imagine it? I've never found myself in such a ridiculous situation in my life! That television Frend wouldn't let us out!" Mrs. Jones said in a barrage of words as Troy listened with a sympathetic ear.

Mrs. Jones laughed-out aloud as she looked around at the eucalypts swaying in the breeze then fixed her gaze on Troy again.

"... Our Frend wouldn't let us out unless we apologised 'in the correct tone', she said all the time. Can you believe it Troy? We spent two weeks trapped down there trying to apologise to a television set for gods sake!" Mrs. Jones said as her two kids starting playing in a tree nearby enjoying their freedom.

Meanwhile Jonesy tapped angrily away on the small keyboard that was part of the switchboard that operated the functions of his elaborate underground home.

"What are you doing now Jonesy?" Troy enquired as he began to realise the ramifications of his neighbours ordeal.

"Well firstly, and quite obviously, I'm going to do what I set out to do two weeks ago and that is to get rid of my television Frend", he said firmly as he continued to tap away on the switchboard, "and that is what I'm telling the Frend Corporation headquarters now."

"Why didn't you just tell your television Frend that two weeks ago?" Troy asked finding this situation very intriguing.

"I did! I did!" Jonesy snapped back at Troy, "and then the television Frend told us we should apologise for having such an idea, 'in the correct tone', or we wouldn't be allowed out of the house!" Jonesy said with growing frustration and disbelief. Mrs. Jones turned to Troy and continued the story.

"We spent two weeks down there trying to apologise to that stupid Frend, but it wouldn't accept our apology and wouldn't let us out! We could have been there forever! Thank goodness you came along with your key-card, Troy. We're so thankful, really", Mrs. Jones said patting Troy on the back.

Jonesy finished tapping into the switchboard and went out of the glasshouse into the yard and stood next to Troy.

"There!" he said brushing his hands together, "that should fix everything. I've told them to take my television Frend back to the Frend Corporation

immediately and I also fed them the complaints I've itemised over the past two weeks of captivity.”

“Will they deliver a new model Frend at the same time ... ?” Troy asked.

“Certainly not!” Jonesy retorted, “it will be awhile before I let a Frend into my home again”, he said as his expression turned to self-pity, “we were completely helpless Troy. Everything in the house operated just fine ... except the front door which wouldn't open! We had food, running water, everything, but the television Frend wouldn't unlock the door and wouldn't let us ring out. When the school rang ten days ago to find out where the kids were, the Frend answered the call and said the family had gone on vacation!”

Jonesy wiped his brow and continued. “And then each time we tried different ways of apologising to the Frend it just responded by saying our apology wasn't 'in the correct tone!' I didn't know whether to laugh or cry throughout the whole terrible episode ... we all nearly went mad!”

Jonesy wallowed in his own utter disbelief as the story became more incredulous until a large truck pulled up on the road. It was the Frend Corporation and the two men who had delivered Troy's television Frend the previous day stepped from the truck and walked up the path towards the glasshouse.

“We're here to pick up your television Frend Mr. Jones ... “ the delivery man mumbled averting eye contact as he shook hands with Jonesy, “we're very sorry about any inconvenience it may have caused you.”

Troy looked on silently as the men walked inside the glasshouse and then disappeared through the open door and down the staircase. It had already crossed Troy's mind that he could take this opportunity to have his television Frend 'taken away' and be done with the whole business.

But then again, Troy thought to himself, he would be most interested to see what his newly installed Frend would have to say about the next door neighbours experience.

The Jones family stood by angrily as the delivery men carried the television Frend out the door and down the path. Mrs. Jones turned to Troy.

“Whatever made you visit us now anyway?” she asked inquisitively as the television was loaded into the back of the truck.

“Well actually I came over to tell Jonesy the good news about the Frend I had installed yesterday ...” Troy replied as his voice trailed-off. The two Jones kids gave an embarrassed giggle, “anyway, we'll see you later at the bar-b-que.”

Troy strolled off towards his house next door as the sun began to set. It was a good fifty metre hike through the sometimes thick wild bush before he reached the side gate of his property. He walked in the back door of his house and sat down on the sofa in the living-room opposite his television Frend. He gazed at the blank screen of his Frend and gathered his thoughts about the happenings of that day.

“Switch on please Frend”, Troy commanded as the television Frend flickered on and the beautiful woman appeared on the screen and smiled.

“Good evening Troy, how are you?” she asked politely.

“I'm fine thanks. What is our next social engagement?” he enquired getting straight to the point.

“This evening you have a bar-b-que with the Jones's next door like you do each fortnight”, the Frend announced.

“Good”, Troy replied slowly, “ ... and do you think the Jones's will be there...? Or will they still be locked-up like caged animals at the mercy of their Frend?” Troy asked leaning forward with a menacing body language.

The woman on the screen appeared momentarily flustered.

“I'm terribly sorry Troy”, she replied in a very apologetic tone, “would you be good enough to talk now to the Vice-President of the Frend Corporation...?”

Suddenly an affable middle-aged businessman in a smart suit seated at his desk came on the screen. He smiled at Troy and then addressed him.

“Hullo Troy. I want to be perfectly candid with you. I am fully aware of what happened to your neighbour and his family next door”, he continued interlocking his fingers on his desk, “and the Frend Corporation will compensate them in total for any physical or emotional wear and tear. But I want to make it perfectly clear that the model Frend the Jones family had next door was a much older model than the completely flawless one you have installed here”, the Vice-President announced proudly.

“So this model wouldn't hold me captive if I mentioned I wanted to return it?” Troy enquired.

The Vice-President looked surprised and then laughed.

“Goodness gracious no. Absolutely not”, he said as he leaned forward on his desk to speak in confidence to Troy. “Listen, our technicians here at the Frend Corporation have already done a scan of your neighbours Frend and they discovered a tiny latent computer virus that is as rare as hens teeth and only ever occur in those models”, he said as he tried to reassure Troy. “The new

model Frend you are looking at is perfect!” the Vice-President said sitting back in his chair and folding his arms proudly.

“What type of virus was it?” Troy asked.

“Well obviously it's the product from the mind of some madly humorous hacker who probably worked for the Frend Corporation many years ago in the early days”, he explained. “When these television Friends were first manufactured the public, and probably a lot of the electronic engineers working here, held them up for ridicule. More than likely one or two 'clever and witty type' viruses found their sneaky little ways into a few of the early models”, he said brushing aside the incident.

“So you think that some hacker installed a virus that essentially made the Frend demand an apology if the owner wanted to return it?” Troy responded slightly amused by this creditable answer.

“Well, in a word, yes. It's unfortunate, but it certainly wouldn't occur in these new model Friends”, said the Vice-President confidently as he continued, “... but, if you want to return your television Frend you only had installed yesterday, that's fine by us ... “

“No no, that's alright”, Troy replied defensively, “I believe you. I was just interested, that's all.”

“Fine then”, concluded the Vice-President, “it was a pleasure talking to you. Send my kind regards to your family. Good evening.” He disappeared from the screen and was replaced by the beautiful woman again. She smiled warmly.

“Well I hope that clears up any reservations you may have about me Troy”, the Frend said politely.

“It does, and thank you”, Troy said as Sandra arrived home along with their youngest son Chips. They had been shopping together and were pleased to see Troy was home.

“Hullo dear”, Sandra said giving Troy a kiss, “you haven't forgotten our bar-b-que this evening with the Jones's have you?” she enquired oblivious to their recent captivity.

“No. And I'm looking forward to seeing Jonesy again”, Troy said concealing his knowledge of what had happened. He had decided it would be better to let Mrs. Jones tell Sandra all about the ordeal. Whichever way she found out it would spell trouble for the television Frend and Troy knew it was a storm he would just have to ride out.

Chapter 9

A few weeks slipped by without any problems. Much to the surprise of Troy there had been no pressure on him to throw out the Frend. In fact Sandra had adjusted to the domestic convenience rather well. Nor did it seem to affect the performance of Team Providence as had been feared by some.

The only member of the Day family who hadn't met the Frend was the seventeen-year-old daughter Stacy because she was currently at boarding school studying drama. Although her school was located in Melbourne, sections of it were situated around the country and overseas. The drama department had its classrooms, theatre and accommodation at Mawson in the Antarctic and Stacy had been living there for some months now.

The drama department put on a major production every few months and Stacy had a big part in this one. So Troy and Sandra decided to fly down to the Antarctic to see it.

The crowded airbus circled the snow-covered city of Mawson as Sandra chatted away with some other parents on the same flight. Troy was sitting upstairs in the glass-dome area of the airbus which gave much better views and this flight was no exception. It was a clear sunny day and the huge ice-bergs and snow-drifts looked as magnificent as ever. The actual city of Mawson was quite extensive and the aerial view from the airbus clearly showed all the streets and buildings and it really resembled a white metropolis.

Inside the airport terminal after a smooth landing, Sandra was surprised to learn that Troy and a few of the other husbands had decided to take the dog sled to their hotel instead of the usual snow-bus. This journey would take a good forty-five minutes and was more expensive than the other modes of transport between the airport and Mawson. Some of the parents had never been on a dog sled ride and since the play they were all going to see was a drama 'set in ice' they all agreed that they should get the atmosphere right from the beginning.

Before long sixteen panting huskies towing a sled came skidding to a standstill alongside the airport terminus bus-stop. Troy handed the master of the sled his plastic card and the three couples sat down on the seats in the sled. Everyone was wearing thick jackets and mitts, scarves, ear-muffs and fleecy lined boots to keep them warm on the journey.

"Mush! Mush!", the master of the sled commanded as the huskies pounded-off along the iced-trail. Troy saw himself as some sort of trans-antarctic explorer on a dangerous expedition as dozens of Emperor penguins waddled out of the way of the huskies thundering along while the passengers

chatted away excitedly under the crisp sunshine. Crevasses came and went and the city of Mawson loomed large like a huge ice precipice.

Soon the dog sled was slipping along the crowded streets of Mawson by-passing snow-cats and ice-mobiles as the team of husky dogs pounded up 'Shackleton Parade'.

“Can you drop us at the 'Scott Base Hotel'?” Troy asked the driver as the sled veered off the road and pulled-up outside the entrance of their hotel. Troy and Sandra clambered from the sled clutching their overnight baggage and waved goodbye as the huskies surged-off with the other passengers on tow to their respective accommodation.

Troy strolled up to the reception desk to check-in while Sandra surveyed the hotel lobby which was mainly white and had an enormous crop of icicles hanging from the middle of the high ceiling.

Around the expansive lobby Emperor penguins lounged on seats and stood in small groups mixing easily with visiting Eskimos, hotel guests and assorted Antarctic wildlife. As Troy strolled back from reception into the hotel lobby shuffling his cards into his wallet an Emperor penguin waddled up behind him and followed in his footsteps until he reached Sandra.

Suddenly the penguin snatched the plastic card from Troy's hand and went to waddle off.

“Hey! What's going on here?!” Troy exclaimed in horror. The Emperor penguin stopped in its tracks and turned around returning the card to Troy.

“It's alright. .. it's me!”, said the penguin in a young women's voice as she parted the rubber mask to reveal her smiling face underneath. It was Stacy, Troy and Sandra's forever dramatic daughter, “we came down here to welcome you”, said Stacy as a group of Emperor penguins crowded around Troy and Sandra, “and we thought we'd wear our costumes from the play.”

“Well, I would never have picked it”, laughed Troy, “ ... I was just about to have you thrown in the heater.”

The group decided to adjourn to a nearby cafe in Shackleton Parade. The three girls decked out in their Emperor penguin outfits sat on one side of the table with Troy and Sandra on the other as cappuccino and cakes were ordered. Stacy and her friends were very eager to discuss the reasons behind the altercation between Alexander and Cathy and how the formation flying was going with Team Providence.

Everyone at the cafe table had different opinions about Troy's television

Frend and they were very interested to find out that it was working well and hadn't caused any problems.

“Cathy is probably worried that the Frend will make Alexander go lazy”, Stacy said, “and his flying might suffer ... you know, couldn't be bothered flapping his wings”. The three girls giggled in agreement, but they all accepted this hadn't been the case.

In fact Sandra was almost a supporter of the Frend now and when she told Stacy and her girlfriends all about what happened to the Jones's next door, she still concluded that Troy's more recent model seemed okay.

“That's right”, Troy complied, “and I don't know why everyone doesn't have one!” Troy was clearly relishing in the success of his installation. The Emperor penguins and Sandra went quiet for a moment.

“We've got a Frend in our drama department actually”, Stacy revealed, “and we use it to practice our lines on.” This led the conversation onto the play. It was clearly a success story around the city of Mawson.

Most nights were capacity audiences in the medium-sized theatre and the critics were most impressed with the realism of the penguins and, not least, with Stacy's role.

“When we were work-shopping the play”, Stacy continued, “the Frend was contributing some great ideas, and in the end we let it write the entire play”, she said proudly.

Troy allowed his gaze to wander outside where snow had begun to fall as various snow-cats and assorted pedestrians shuffled-by along Shackleton Parade. He wondered to himself whether it was such a good idea to let the drama departments television Frend dictate the entire play.

“What do you think about their drama Frend writing the play we're seeing tonight Troy ...?” Sandra enquired noticing him deep in thought.

“Well, 1 ... urn”, Troy tried to collect his real thoughts on the matter, “well the main thing is that it's a good play ... “ he said as his voice trailed-off.

“Obviously”, Sandra retorted “but where is the benefit for these human drama students?”

Sandra was right of course and Stacy realised that. Nevertheless they all agreed they wanted a good play that was successful, so it didn't really matter who wrote it. A second round of cappuccinos was ordered and they planned their activities for the afternoon. Troy and Sandra decided to go ice-skating and the three Emperor penguins wanted to return to the drama department to rest up

for their evening performance.

As they were leaving the cafe the conversation returned to the author of the play, the drama departments television Friend. Stacy calmly divulged that this Friend was the latest model, the same as Troy's, and had in fact corresponded with Troy's Friend in writing the play. The three Emperor penguins glanced at Troy to see his response.

His expression didn't change at all until he stepped out into the bustling main road of Mawson. An icy wind had picked up and was blowing across the vast flat sheet-ice that surrounded the Antarctic city.

Troy's eyes widened in surprise. Up in the sky above the glass and white buildings the luminous phenomenon of an aurora was taking place in the upper atmosphere which appeared in the sky like moving curtains of coloured light.

Chapter 10

Troy and Sandra had a very entertaining time watching their daughter Stacy star in her drama department play, 'Set in Ice '. The rest of the audience also enjoyed the production and in the theatre foyer afterwards the Emperor penguins, a few walruses, seals and the audience partied late into the Antarctic night.

Troy and Sandra had planned to return home the following morning, but Sandra was so impressed with the play that she decided to stay on at the Scott Base Hotel for a few days and see the production again. Stacy and her girlfriends were very pleased about this as they all got on very well with Sandra. Troy had business commitments and had to return to Australia, so the next morning he waved goodbye to Sandra as he boarded the snow-bus and headed-off to the airport.

By mid-morning Troy had reached home. He stepped out of the taxi and strolled up the path to his house. Maybe his body temperature was still adjusting from his time in the Antarctic, but he did notice that it seemed very cold around his house and this was strange.

He became more suspicious when he reached his front-door and found a number of icicles hanging along the top of the door and from the door-knob. He noticed that the front-door had a thin layer of ice covering it. Troy took out his plastic key-card and tried to slide it into the slot but it had frozen over and wouldn't work.

Feeling slightly confused for a moment Troy stepped back and surveyed the front of his two-storey house and noticed that all the window-shutters were closed and they also had clusters of icicles hanging from them. He stepped forward again and used his key-card to scrape-away the ice from the slot.

His hands and face felt cold but finally the key-card went into the slot and there was the familiar whiz-click sound that meant the door was now unlocked. Troy brushed the icicles from the door-knob and turned it, then he flung the front-door open. A wall of ice stood in front of him.

Troy was dumbfounded. He tapped it with his knuckles. 'That's solid ice', he thought to himself as his face became even colder. He stood motionless staring into the solid ice. Where was Chips? And Alexander? The family cat and dog? Were they all frozen inside a huge ice-block? All these horrible questions reverberated inside Troy's mind as he stepped over to the small switch-board and brushed aside the icicles. On the keys he hurriedly tapped-in instructions to override the television Frened and open all the shutters covering

the windows, sound the alarm next door and obviously switch-on the central heating.

Within seconds Jonesy the next door neighbour arrived.

“What's wrong? An intruder?” Jonesy blurted out as he breathlessly skidded to a standstill, his face stopping inches from the solid ice.

“I've arrived home to a house frozen in solid ice!” Troy said in exasperated disbelief. They both stood there silently. “Well Chips isn't in there because he's away on an excursion”, Troy suddenly remembered.

“And I saw Alexander training with Team Providence this morning”, Jonesy added with a sigh of relief that calmed the situation momentarily. “This is sillier than what happened to us”, Jonesy protested with a broad neighbourly smile, “are you going to get rid of your Frennd now... ? “

“Well the Frennd Corporation can't just waltz-in and pick up the television because it's embedded in a house of solid ice!”, Troy replied in a tone of self-pity, “and I'm not even sure if the Frennd is responsible. And if it is, why would it do something like this?” he continued incredulously.

Jonesy meanwhile had quickly formed a theory on what had happened. He had discovered a small gap just below the top of the front-door but above the main area of solid ice. He peered into it.

“It looks to me that your Frennd has turned on the air-conditioners as cold as possible and also turned on the indoor sprinklers, which are really only there in case of fire”, Jonesy explained as Troy considered his theory, “and the intense cold inside the house is freezing the water as it lands thus causing your house to be filled by one big ice-block.”

Troy and Jonesy started walking around the outside of the frozen home.

“I did what you did and overrode the television Frennd and switched on all the heaters in the house. It's certainly going to be a mess of water soon”, Troy said scratching his chin.

“What will Sandra say?” Jonesy enquired.

“She won't be back from Mawson for a couple of days”, Troy replied looking more worried than before, “and I think I can get it all cleaned up before she returns ... she won't be any the wiser”, he said as they reached the back of the house.

Troy brushed away some more icicles from the back door-knob and opened the door once again revealing a wall of solid ice. They decided to go up the back-steps onto the balcony upstairs and gazed into the windows. Again all

they could see was solid ice.

But now the ice was beginning to thaw and water was trickling down the windows and walls. Soon water starting seeping-out from under the back door.

“I think it will take at least six hours to melt”, Jonesy concluded as he tapped his knuckles on the solid ice. Troy turned his back on his frozen home and let his eyes wander over to the Jones's land next door where the gum trees swayed in the gentle breeze and the sunshine warmed his face and hands. He recalled how three weeks earlier he had discovered his neighbours locked in their underground house and now he found his home completely frozen in solid ice.

Troy was very interested to talk to his television Friend. But he would have to wait until the ice melted. By now there was a stream of ice-cold water cascading down the back of the house. While Troy warmed his face in the mid-day sun he noticed a team of fliers circling high-up above his home.

“That looks like Team Providence training up there”, Troy said as he and Jonesy stepped down the stair-case and onto the backyard. They waded ankle-deep through the icy water flowing from the house onto the lawn and looked-up again to see that two fliers had broken away from the team formation flying and were winging their way down towards them. As they glided-in closer their faces revealed the quizzical expressions of Cathy and Alexander.

Jonesy, forever the diplomatic neighbour, strolled-off into the nearby tool shed which was sitting high and dry from the glacier-enveloped main house. There was a frantic flapping of wings as the two fliers hovered-down and landed gracefully next to Troy. Their outspread wings folded-in and Cathy smiled at Troy.

“What's on T.V. today Troy?” Cathy enquired seriously as Alexander used his boot to kick the ice inside the back door.

“I'm just thankful you weren't frozen alive inside!” Troy said trying to count some blessings. Alexander turned and looked angrily at Troy.

“I'm sure I would have noticed if the house was getting cooler. Anyway, I spent the night at Cathy's. But as for the dog and the cat, I don't know ...” Alexander said as his voice quivered slightly in concern about the family pets. At that moment the dog, a black long-haired Afghan-cross, bounded out of the tool shed followed by Jonesy grasping a bucket and mop.

Troy patted the dog as it panted away between slurps of plentiful water now streaming all over the place. The household cat then crept out of the tool shed looking curious. Alexander produced his mobile telephone and started

tapping out some numbers then put it to his ear and looked at Troy.

“Chips Day speaking. May I help you?” came the voice at the other end.

“Alexander here. Where are you?” Alexander enquired in a relieved voice.

“I'm here on the island with my school excursion ... you know that! Why do you ask?” retorted the voice over the mobile phone.

“That's okay”, Alexander replied deciding to reveal nothing, “just seeing how you are, that's all.”

“Well I'm in the middle of a cricket match, Alexander ... do you mind if I get on with my batting!?” Chips said in an irritated voice. Alexander put away his mobile phone.

“That accounts for all of the family”, he said as they continued to survey the thawing house, “but we don't know if anyone else could be in there ... “ Alexander stated as he glanced at Troy, “ ... other than your Frend. .. “

Water was now pouring off the back balcony like a waterfall and other streams were gushing into the overflowing drains in an increasing flood of freezing water. Along with Jonesy holding his bucket and mop they all waded around to the side of the house as water cascaded from overflowing down-pipes and splashed onto the garden around the side-yard.

Jonesy was slightly worried that the deluge of water might flood into his property next door and fill his underground home, but he didn't let on his concern. At any rate his family were all out shopping so they would be spared another crisis.

The central heating throughout the house was now working at full pressure and the solid ice that filled every room of the house was melting fast as they all reached the front of the house. Water was flowing out like rapids from the front door and down the path into the street where it flooded into the gutters and down the storm-water drains.

A local council emergency truck with yellow and orange lights flashing luminously skidded to a halt outside the Day residence. Two men in gumboots and raincoats sprang out urgently.

“Burst main pipe?” one yelled over to Troy as he waved them away.

“No. It's okay”, Cathy interjected, “it's only Troy's house, it's become set in ice and is now melting. No big drama really”, she said shrugging her shoulders. The two local council workers retreated into their trucks and drove off. Alexander tried to salvage Troy's damaged pride.

“Come on Cathy, let's get back to our formation training”, Alexander said as he put his arm around Troy’s shoulders, “it's only a minor cold-snap.”

Cathy and Alexander spread their wings and then flew off into the sky to rejoin Team Providence who were treading-air high above Troy’s house and were no doubt eager to learn what had happened. And now there wasn't much Troy and Jonesy could do but be wait and watch the ice melt.

After a few hours, but what seemed like an ice-age to Troy, only about three feet of ice remained throughout the ground floor of the house. In the lounge-room the television Frend was still set in ice but as it continued to melt the top half of the screen came into view. The curtains were drying above the ice-line and steam wafted from the walls as the central heating blew-out hot air speeding the thaw. Jonesy had returned home to have a sauna.

Troy clambered over the remaining ice on all-fours and skated into the lounge-room snow-ploughing to a standstill opposite the top-half of his television Frend.

“Switch on please Frend”, Troy commanded. It flickered on and the beautiful thirty-year-old woman appeared on the screen. Only her eyes could be seen as the rest of the television was still embedded in the ice that filled the lounge-room.

“I couldn't help but notice when I arrived home from the Antarctic a few hours ago that my home was frozen rock-solid in ice”, he mentioned calmly. The beautiful woman looked up at Troy and she sneezed.

“Oh.. There you are Troy ... “ the Frend replied in innocent surprise, “How are you today ... ?”

“What is the meaning of this Frend!? Is there something terribly wrong with you?” Troy said looking around at the solid ice under him and the slush and icy water flowing out the door. The Frend had an expression of guilt on her face.

“I'm really very sorry Troy. Would you mind if the Vice-President of the Frend Corporation spoke to you please?” she said before disappearing from the screen to be replaced by the affable and pleasant businessman seated at his desk who had addressed Troy some three weeks earlier. The Vice-President leaned forward and smiled up at Troy.

“Hullo there Mr. Day”, he said warmly, “if there’s any damage at all to your house we will compensate you completely. You know, when we started manufacturing this latest model television Frend, the excellent one you have in your possession now, we knew there may be one or two minor hiccups that

would need to be ironed-out and ... “

“Listen here!”, Troy interrupted angrily, “I want your Corporation to come and take this set away as soon as it's free of its self-inflicted glacier entombment! Do you understand?”

“Of course Sir”, the Vice-President said yielding immediately. He vanished from the screen and the woman reappeared, this time clutching a handkerchief as she sniffed and sobbed in self-pity.

“I'm sorry Troy ... but I don't like being treated like a piece of furniture, especially a table”, she said wiping the tears from her eyes.

Troy looked down at the television embedded in the ice with disbelief at what he had just heard. He turned around on the slushy ice and scrambled out of the room and into the back yard where he stood in ankle-deep water.

After another couple of hours most of the ice had melted and drained away. The atmosphere in the house was dank as Troy walked back inside and sat down on the damp sofa. The television Frend was still sobbing away and she looked at Troy apologetically and tried to raise a faint smile.

“You see Troy? Most of the ice has gone. Everything is fine”, she said optimistically.

“I'm sorry, but my decision is final. You'll have to go”, Troy announced firmly. He watched her as she tried to compose herself. Her long brown hair was slightly dishevelled and her low-cut dress a bit crumpled. She appeared vulnerable and Troy couldn't help but feel sorry for her. He wondered about her earlier comment that she didn't want to be treated like 'a piece of furniture, especially a table', and what exactly this meant.

Everything went quiet. Only the sound of water dropping onto the damp floor could be heard. They both stared at each other.

“Would you mind if the Vice-President of the Frend Corporation spoke to you again please Troy?” she asked politely. Troy nodded and she disappeared from the screen and was instantly replaced by the Vice-President seated at his desk in a plush office setting. This time his arms were folded and he looked more businessman-like than before.

“Hullo again Mr. Day”, he said in a pleasant manner, “on behalf of the Frend Corporation I would like to invite you up here to our Headquarters and introduce you to the actual woman your Frend is based on. All expenses on us”, he continued proudly, “once you've met her in the flesh, you'll want to keep her.”

Troy was startled by the invitation. He definitely knew that these television Friends were advanced pieces of technology. But to go to their source where they were made and actually meet the person they were based on for their image on the screen was asking a lot.

But then again, he felt a strange bonding with the very beautiful woman who was his television Friend and to meet her in the flesh would be quite an adventure. Troy was deep in thought when the door-bell rang. He stood up from the damp sofa and walked down the passageway squelching on the soggy carpet and opened the front door. Standing there were the two men from the Friend Corporation.

“We're here to pick up your television Friend, Mr. Day”, one said politely as they walked into the lounge-room. The Vice-President on the television screen looked intently at Troy.

“Send them away Mr. Day and take-up my offer”, he said advisedly. Troy thought for a moment but the invitation appealed to him and he didn't need much convincing.

“Alright then”, Troy replied, “I'll be keeping the Friend for the time being”, he said to the de liverymen as he showed them the door. When he returned to the lounge-room the beautiful woman was back on the screen and smiling happily.

“That's wonderful Troy!” she said warmly, “and I'm most looking forward to meeting you in person. It will be such an honour.”

Chapter 11

Troy sat comfortably in the first-class compartment of the super-sonic Qantas Concorde gazing out the large windows as it flew over the Tanami Desert on course for arrival at the Ord River International Airport.

There was some apprehension in his thinking due to the uncharted nature of his adventure. His wife Sandra was still in the Antarctic and was unaware of Troy's journey to the top of Australia. Certainly she knew that Troy was always travelling across the continent on various business trips. But this one had nothing to do with Troy's line of work. This was really more a mission of curiosity for Troy and it wasn't lost on him that essentially he was reacting to a domestic crisis over his television Frend.

Looking down on the Northern Territory below him he could see large areas of the desert covered in lush vegetation surviving successfully from the numerous irrigation schemes that criss-crossed the country. Troy's destination was the Kimberleys which was quite heavily populated and was an important area for business and leisure in Australia.

It was only a three hour flight from Melbourne to the Kimberleys and Troy spent most of the time reading the report on the television Friends that Albert had given him three weeks earlier. This time Troy studied it more closely.

It was described as a perfect piece of modem technology and was regarded as computer-hardware at its most advanced in civilisation and yet Troy had experienced first-hand a major flaw in its operation. And this was the latest model, Troy thought to himself.

He could understand the earlier model Friends having some inherent malfunction like what had happened to his next door neighbour Jonesy when he and his family were locked in their house for two weeks by the Frend who demanded an apology from Jonesy for daring to suggest he get rid of it.

But Troy couldn't really comprehend why his new model television Frend would malfunction in such an absurd way by setting his house in ice. At any rate it wouldn't be long before his question would be answered by his meeting at the headquarters of the Frend Corporation.

The pilot announced that the Concorde was about to land and Troy looked out the window to see the Bungle Bungle Ranges. In many ways these strange dome-shaped mountains with their distinct contoured lines circling them in different shades of red and brown were as striking as any of the rock formations throughout the Northern Territory.

However, they were not all the real thing. A few extra Bungle Bungles had been created artificially and were in fact buildings and offices enclosed in dome-shaped glass identical to the colours and shapes of the real ones. It was within one of these man-made Bungles that the Frend Corporation had their headquarters.

The Qantas super-sonic Concorde touched down on the Ord River airport runway and taxied into the terminus. Troy alighted from the plane and was met by a limousine parked on the tarmac. Standing there with his hand outstretched to welcome him was the Vice-President of the Frend Corporation. He was as affable and pleasant as his image portrayed on the television Frend, but this time he was in real life flesh.

“Hullo Mr. Day, welcome to the Kimberleys”, he said shaking hands with Troy, “I decided to meet you personally, if that's alright?” he asked as he opened the red limousine door for Troy to step in.

“Yes, thank you very much”, Troy replied enjoying his newly-found importance. Soon the limousine was humming along the narrow road that wove its way amongst the Bungle Bungle Ranges.

It was a long vehicle in which Troy could stretch out his legs and look up through the sun-roof to admire the shape, texture, colour and variety of these scenic roundly mountains.

Before long the limousine slowed down and stopped in front of huge gates embedded in a steep rock face made of glass. They parted in a grand manner and the limousine drove through and then pulled up outside another entrance. Troy stepped out and strolled into a lobby which was large and bright and had various rock-pools interspersed with desks and office partitions.

A huge sign dominated the entire lobby which read, 'The Frend Corporation' and in smaller letters, 'Head Office'. Business people and assorted staff went about their daily work which created an impressively active workplace environment. The Vice-President sat down at a large desk next to a rock pool and he gestured Troy to sit down opposite on the plush crocodile skinned seat.

The Vice-President strummed his fingertips and leaned forward on his desk in an amiable way to address Troy.

“Now Mr. Day, first of all, I would like to congratulate you on behalf of the entire Frend Corporation for the astute decision you made in regards to your television Frend”, he expressed congenially to Troy, “and in our minds we consider the latest model Frend to be virtually perfect in every sense of the

word. As you know by now, the beautiful woman you interact with on your screen is a computer image and is worked by a highly sophisticated computer programme that gives it the ability to run your household, answer any questions and do anything that is required of it”, he explained patiently.

Troy allowed his eyes to wander around the large lobby as the Vice-President continued speaking.

“The technology involved in these television Friends has made them capable of thought, humour, imagination and endless other processes”, he said as Troy watched a secretary at a nearby desk throw her biscuit into a rock pool. A number of small fish surfaced quickly and gobbled-up the crumbs in a feeding frenzy.

“And do you know”, the Vice-President said in a matter-of-fact way, “you could have knocked us over with a feather when we found out that the latest model Friend had a few minor glitches that our technicians have already pinpointed...” Troy looked back at him across the desk.

“Oh? So you know what the malfunction is?” Troy enquired as his expression turned to surprise. The Vice-President sat back in his chair defensively.

“Well yes ... we do know...” he replied nodding slightly nervously.

“What is it then?” Troy asked impassively. The Vice-President looked around to make sure nobody was within earshot. He paused for a moment and then continued in a hushed apologetic tone that was barely audible.

“...Probably early on in the development of this latest model Friend some born-again Mills and Boon disciple thought he would be terribly helpful and slip in a few emotions into the programme data”, the Vice-President said quietly, “you know, things like love, lust, jealousy for example, infatuation, sarcasm ... emotions like that ...” Troy leaned forward in equal concern and enquired why.

“Probably thought he was doing us a favour”, concluded the Vice-President with a sigh, “but this minor malfunction hasn't really helped at all.

In fact it's been a dam nuisance. Anyway, our technicians here did a remote control scan of your television Friend and found out why it decided to freeze your house.”

Troy sat on the edge of his crocodile-skin chair in anticipation. The Vice-President drummed his fingers on his desk for a moment and then he looked squarely into the eyes of Troy.

“Did you place a table-cloth over your television Frend when it was delivered three weeks ago?” the Vice-President asked with a solemn face. Troy scratched his chin and thought for awhile. Then suddenly he remembered.

“I didn't, but my wife did”, Troy said snapping his fingers, “yes, that's right. She didn't want the Frend installed in the first place and when it arrived she put a table-cloth over it and joked that it was an expensive table!”

“Well Mr. Day, I'm afraid your television Frend reacted to this insult”, said the Vice-President looking sympathetic, “after all, it is a highly complex computer that can draw on various emotions and probably pure sarcasm bubbled to the surface over this issue ... “ he said trying to remain affable.

A lot of thoughts raced through Troy's mind. Not least the recognition of the woman who was walking through the office partitions towards him. It was the beautiful woman who appeared on the screen of his television Frend.

“Ah, good', the Vice-President said as she reached desk, “I would like you to meet Mavis, who you no doubt recognize ... “ Troy stood up to greet her. “Mavis works here for the Frend Corporation and will be happy to give you a guided tour. I'm sure that once you have seen everything your concerns will be put to rest... it was nice meeting you Mr. Day”, said the Vice-President as he sat down and resumed his work.

“It must be strange for you to see me in real life”, Mavis said to Troy as they walked out of the lobby area and into a passageway that stretched in a straight line for as far as the eye could see.

Along the way they passed numerous windows that revealed different areas of manufacturing where the television Frends were produced. In each area large numbers of technicians and assorted workers busied themselves on extensive assembly lines creating the finished product that was the television Frend.

Troy listened attentively as Mavis explained the various facets of production. She went to great lengths to make Troy understand that it was only her image that appeared on the screen of his television Frend and that's where the association ended.

“I can barely get through my twelve-times table”, she joked as she reinforced the explanation over her role in the Frend. “ ... It is really just a complicated and highly intricate computer you are dealing with in these sets. My face is a computerized image. I'm not nearly as smart as I appear on the screen.”

Mavis clearly wasn't a dim-wit either, Troy thought to himself, as their walk along the seemingly endless corridor continued deep into the Bungle

Bungles that housed the Frend Corporation.

Finally they reached a spiral escalator that took them right up to the top of the artificial Bungle where there were restaurants, cafes, shops and various apartments for the employees. The penthouse apartment Mavis occupied had a breathtaking panoramic view of the rest of the Bungle Bungle Ranges.

It turned out that Mavis actually came from Melbourne originally and had been working for the Frend Corporation for a few years now. She appeared more attractive in the flesh than she did on the screen in Troy's lounge-room and her body language revealed that she was quite attracted to Troy even though he was twenty years older.

As the afternoon dissolved into the evening the two of them found that they got on famously. They had a wonderful dinner together and sipped champagne as a flaming red sun set over the Bungle Bungle Ranges. And there was more because Mavis invited Troy to sleep the night in her apartment in the same bed.

Chapter 12

Early next morning the sun sprang up amidst the crevices and canyons of the Bungle Bungles. It was a seemingly perfect sunrise.

After breakfast Mavis bade Troy farewell with dual assurances of further meetings and soon he was happily seated in the first-class compartment of the Qantas super-sonic Concorde as it took off at high speed for Melbourne.

As Troy journeyed home high above the continent of Australia he wondered about the condition of his house when he arrived back. It had completely dried out before he left and was sparkling clean thanks to the wash it had received from the melting ice-flow. But what effect would his night at the Frend Corporation headquarters have on his television Frend?

Various worst-case scenarios entered his mind as he stepped out of the taxi and strolled up the drive to his house. These were ill-founded because when he opened his front door and walked into his home Sandra was there to greet him enthusiastically along with Alexander and Chips.

“I'm really glad you did that”, Sandra stated as she gave Troy a hug and a kiss and then patted his back.

“You did the right thing”, continued Alexander looking relieved and thankful.

Troy was surprised. How on earth did they know? He felt rather guilty. Even Chips had an encouraging word to say.

“Well done. You're a brave man”, said Chips proudly.

Troy felt his face blush. And he was lost for words. Possibly Mavis had told them via her beautiful image on the television Frend that she had decided to bare all and blurt out the truth of Troy's indiscretion. What sort of deception was this? Troy continued to search for answers to this new bombshell as they all walked along the passageway. In many ways it was more devastating than finding his house frozen in ice.

Troy could feel some perspiration gather around his neck and trickle down his back. He really didn't know what to say, or even think. And soon he would be face-to-face with his television Frend and would be chatting to the image of Mavis who he had only hours earlier encountered in the flesh. Sandra chattered on with a barrage of encouragement and pride.

“It's just a load off our shoulders that you actually went through with it darling, you strong-willed husband!” she continued gladly.

Troy finally found something to say. He guessed that under the circumstances he should go with the flow of domestic adulation.

“Well Mavis is a very nice young lass”, he said as his voice trailed off in apprehension. He still felt terribly embarrassed and his privacy seemed to be violated in a big way.

Finally they all reached the lounge-room and Troy urgently glanced into the corner where the television Frend normally stood. But the corner was vacant. There was no television Frend to be seen. Maybe the family had moved it to another place in the house Troy thought to himself. Even worse, it could be covered again with a table-cloth and he couldn't recognise it. He shuddered silently to himself at the ramifications of such a thing.

“Where's my Frend?” Troy enquired in a whisper.

“What?” Sandra asked perplexed, “you had it taken away didn't you?”

Troy's face went blank. The room became very silent.

“Who the hell is Mavis?” Chips threw in like a missile.

Everyone looked at each other. Troy's face went bright red.

“Urn..,” he cleared his throat, “urn ... well Mavis is the name of the woman who appears on the television Frend that used to be in this corner ... “ Troy said as he pointed to the empty space.

Then suddenly Troy realised that his family thought he had the Frend taken away by the Frend Corporation and they didn't know about his journey to the Bungle Bungles. A huge sense of relief overcame Troy but it was replaced by a strange sense of mystery. What had happened to the television Frend? Chips looked puzzled.

“Mavis? Was that her name? Mavis? Funny name really”, Chips said finding the situation a bit confusing. “You did have the Frend taken away, didn't you?” Alexander enquired sensing the same mystery as Troy. “Actually ... no. I didn't”, Troy replied honestly. “But the Frend set the entire house in ice, for heavens sake. Wasn't that enough to have it removed?” Alexander said blowing apart the lies and deceit. “Cathy told me, you know dear”, Sandra said erupting, “your stupid little 73

television Frend was no better than the one the Jones's had next door! Let's face it, the Frend is a dud! I TOLD YOU SO!” Sandra screamed angrily.

“Look, just calm down everyone”, Troy said feeling uneasy with the whole situation, “all I can think is that it must have been stolen.”

The family all looked at each other. Burglary was almost unheard of in these times and so such a thing was hard to contemplate. At any rate, Troy rang the police and they arrived without any fuss or bother and confidently predicted they could find the culprit and have it back in no time.

“All these types of machines have little tracking tags in them”, the Policeman said as he happily sipped on a nice cup of tea and chomped on a biscuit, “so all we have to do is have your Frend tracked and go and pick it up and return it to you.”

Troy wasn't altogether sure he wanted the Frend back. In the short space of time he had been home and discovered the television Frend missing he had already begun to enjoy the uncluttered freedom of having a vacant corner in the lounge-room.

Certainly he had found his meeting with Mavis most rewarding and he was relieved that his family were not aware of his trip to the Bungle Bungles to inspect the Frend Corporation. But at the same time he had found the Frend moderately stifling and it had caused unwanted friction within the household.

And then there were the major malfunctions perpetrated by his Frend in setting his house in solid ice and his next door neighbours Frend who had held Jonesy and his family in captivity for two weeks.

So when the police rang later and informed Troy that the tracking tag had evidently been removed from the television Frend which meant it couldn't be located, Troy felt that the whole episode was over and the Frend was out of his life. He had also telephoned the Vice-President of the Frend Corporation and informed him of the disappearance and had subsequently rejected the offer of a replacement.

Alexander was the one who benefited most because Cathy was very pleased about the mystery disappearance. It meant that Team Providence didn't have the worry in the back of their minds about the effect the Frend could have on their captain and they could concentrate on their flying. And flying was an endless preoccupation with Alexander and Team Providence.

At their headquarters perched on top of a tall tower overlooking the lower Yarra wetlands near the West Gate Bridge, Team Providence worked hard to maintain their edge over the rival flying teams.

They faced a difficult contest a fortnight away when they would be racing and formation flying over a country town in Queensland where the weather conditions were always hazardous and completely unpredictable.

And Cathy wasn't entirely happy with Alexander either. As the team

gathered in the Meteorological Room to have a seminar on flying in a thunderstorm Cathy maintained her enquiries into the disappearance of the Frend.

“Do you think it still works?” Cathy asked Alexander quietly as they sat down in the middle of the room.

“Almost certainly”, Alexander answered abruptly, “these television Frends keep on going regardless. This is the only problem with the whole thing. You see, if the Frend Corporation had come and taken it away they would have closed it down completely making it unusable”, Alexander whispered to Cathy, “unfortunately this wasn't the case. Having it stolen means whoever has it still has a working television Frend.”

“So Troy’s Frend could be sitting in someone else’s living-room carrying on as usual?” Cathy concluded in a conspiratorial murmur.

“Correct. But I doubt it”, Alexander said confidently, “more than likely it's already in tiny pieces selling on the spare parts market. Anyway we may never know so don't worry about it. We've got more important things to think about”, Alexander said as the room went silent and the team concentrated their attention on the person at the front of the room shuffling weather maps and assorted papers around.

“Okay. Now before we start discussing the velocity and effect of a bolt of lightning on your flapping, have you any questions about the destination of your training today?” he enquired looking around the room expectantly.

“Yes!” Alexander replied quickly, “I think we should drop in on the cricket!” There was a loud chorus of approval from the team members. One of the advantages of being the top flying team around the traps was the permission to fly in and watch any open air event. And on this day the cricket being played on the Bay Island was reaching an absorbing stage.

So the seminar was brief and to the point and soon the team were strapping on their wings and methodically doing their stretches and relaxation exercises in preparation for flight. From their take-off platform they could clearly see out over Port Phillip Bay.

A fresh sea-breeze caused the edges of their wings to tremble as they opened them out to their full expanse. They stood in a line and in exact formation leaped off the platform and soared high over the West Gate Bridge.

The eight flyers glided and flapped in majestic formation as they winged their way towards the middle of Port Phillip Bay where one of civilizations greatest engineering achievements was located. It was a stadium within an

island and was known as The Bay Island.

As an artificial man-made structure it was one of the most highly regarded landmarks on earth and it was in the same club as the seven wonders of the world, if not better.

Team Providence sighted the island and soared towards it. They went into their most favoured 'V' formation with Alexander flying at the apex. From an aerial distance it looked like a heavily vegetated island with a central mountain. At the top of the mountain was a crater within which a sports stadium was situated large enough to seat two hundred thousand people.

The stands inside the stadium went to six levels surrounding the green manicured field where the cricket test match was in progress. The entire island structure stood on enormous poles that sank deep into the seabed of Port Phillip Bay some thirty feet below. In this subterranean shelf under the island a sea-life thrived on the various artificial reefs.

The team of fliers went into a glide as they passed over the lip of the stadium high above the medium-sized crowd that filled parts of the stadium and the playing field that hosted the exciting test match. In every way, Alexander thought to himself as Team Providence soared over the island in exact formation, this sports stadium was unequalled anywhere in the world as a shining example of aesthetic perfection and functional excellence.

Alexander spotted a suitable area on the top level away from heavier crowds of spectators and Team Providence hovered in and landed gracefully closing their wings simultaneously. Cathy always felt a bit self-conscious when she and the team landed at big events, but once they had folded their wings and sat amongst the rest of the crowd people soon stopped staring in utter astonishment and amazed fascination. In this case their arrival was only a minor distraction from the absorbing cricket match that was unfolding in front of them on the playing field.

Cathy loved cricket. She had played in the Australian women's eleven for three years as their best batsman before switching to flying after meeting Alexander. In fact the only thing she regretted was that she couldn't fly onto the ground and face the bowler.

Chapter 13

Troy was no less enthusiastic about the current state of play in the cricket Test match than anyone else and he had consequently decided to attend as much of it as he could regardless of his business commitments.

Unfortunately without his television friend to activate his alarm clock in the morning he over-slept and was running late when he and Sandra set off for the Test match between Australia and England.

They decided not to take the ferry to the Bay Island but instead boarded the fast travelling four-carriage tram-shuttle that left Flinders Street station and ran directly along the sea bed to the Bay Island taking just twelve minutes.

Troy and Sandra could only manage standing room in the crowded tram shuttle as it ascended from the depths of the bay. Peering out through the tram windows and then further through the transparent tube containing the tram-line the sea water became lighter as the tram approached the surface. Suddenly the water line dropped away and the morning rays of bright sunshine beamed into the tram as it rolled onto a plateau that was the Bay Island Tram Stop.

The tram-shuttle glided to a standstill alongside the platform in front of which stood the two hundred metre high mountain that contained the stadium. All the passengers alighted from the tram and stepped onto the wide escalators that wove their way up the side of the mountain to any number of entrances that led into the six levels of the arena.

The journey up the escalators was an adventure in itself Troy thought as the steps moved slowly upwards and the view became breathtaking. In the distance Troy could clearly see the mouth of the Yarra River, the West Gate Bridge and the various towers near it. The You Yangs stood out dramatically on the horizon as closer at hand the escalators continued to pass through eucalypts and various native shrubs that covered the mountainside.

Sandra gazed over to the other end of the Bay Island where the extensive marina was situated. A large ferry had just docked and spectators were streaming from it. Other smaller craft were coming and going from the numerous jetties and piers that complimented the busy marina.

When the wide escalator finally reached the top of its long journey Troy and Sandra turned their backs on the sea waters of Port Phillip Bay surrounding the Bay Island and stepped off the ascending stairs. They strolled through a short tunnel and were confronted by the interior of the man-made mountain which was the impressively large sports stadium.

Troy looked down onto the green playing field below where the cricket match was in progress. Once inside the stadium it was easy to forget that this was a man-made artificial island.

“You Hoo ... !” Cathy cooed over the ambience of the cricket crowd as Sandra looked around and could see the Team Providence members seated amongst the other spectators. They exchanged waves and strolled over to sit in seats nearby.

From their vantage point they could see all of the playing field and also the two huge video screens and scoreboards at either ends of the stadium. Sandra and Cathy sat together along with a few of the other female flyers from Team Providence. The cricket was a great place to have a jolly good chat Sandra thought to herself as they all exchanged theories on the disappearance of Troy’s television friend.

Most of them agreed wholeheartedly with Sandra that it was a big mistake to have Friend installed in the first place and that all they ever caused was trouble. At any rate there was unanimous approval by all of them when Sandra informed them that Troy had decided not to get another one.

“He’s had his fingers frozen and learnt his lesson”, Cathy joked as some of them looked across to Troy a few seats away. He was chatting to some of the other members of Team Providence as they watched the cricket.

The English side were batting and the Australians had set a wide field. The bowler ran in and delivered a high pitched ball which the batsman hit away to the boundary for four runs. There was a ripple of applause as the Australian fieldsman sprinted after the ball and reached it just after it bounced into the white picket fence.

Troy looked across to the giant video screen to see the action in close-up. His heart suddenly missed a beat. Amongst the spectators on the other side of the white picket fence on the boundary line was Mavis.

It was only a fleeting close-up glimpse on the huge video screen but Troy could see Mavis seated there as the fieldsman picked up the cricket ball and threw it back to the wicket-keeper.

Troy glanced over to Alexander who was already looking his way with surprised recognition. Then Troy turned the other way and looked in the direction of Sandra and Cathy who were chatting away. They didn’t seem to have noticed or maybe didn’t even look at the video screen.

Troy took out his small but powerful binoculars and quickly searched the crowd around the boundary. He soon located Mavis. She appeared rather

content all the way down there Troy thought to himself and concluded that she must be in Melbourne on leave from the Frend Corporation.

Whatever the case, Troy felt a bit uncomfortable seeing her image splashed across the giant video screens in the stadium. Alexander came over and sat next to his father Troy.

“I certainly hope they don't hit the ball over there again!” Alexander whispered urgently.

“I know ... it's such a coincidence”, Troy replied slightly relieved that he could share his surprise with someone.

“A lot of people look alike you know”, Alexander said reassuring Troy.

It was all very easy to suppose that the beautiful woman seated all the way down there was only similar to their television Frend, but Troy could plainly see by peering through his binoculars that the woman was Mavis. Anyway, the cricket match continued and Troy tried to concentrate on the game.

The English First Eleven had put together a strong opening partnership in this second innings but a major collapse was due. The Australian captain signalled to the spin bowler to have an over and finish off the Test and most of the crowd had arrived in time to witness this display.

The mid-morning sun shone down on the perfectly manicured ground as a light sea breeze refreshed the excited crowd waiting in hushed anticipation.

The spin bowler ambled up to the stumps and his arm circled over with a small wrist twist releasing the red cricket ball towards the sweating batsman. Zero runs, a hat-trick, a couple of run-outs, more ducks and a few spectacular catches all happened in as many balls as the batting side padded up and unpadded on the bench at the boundary line to save time. It was a dazzling display Troy thought to himself as the crowd roared in approval.

He allowed his gaze to be distracted as it wandered up into the sky and fixed on a large blimp in the likeness of a blue whale that advertised the worthy activity of swimming.

There was another loud eruption from the crowd as the final batsman went out for a duck and people started to stand up and leave the stadium. As the Australian fieldsmen and triumphant spin bowler along with the disillusioned batsmen walked off the ground preparations for the next sporting event unfolded immediately. The Bay Island was an active venue twenty four hours a day.

The umpires took out the stumps just before the firm cricket pitch suddenly

rotated over to be replaced by soft lawn with a white circle in the middle. At either end of the ground the sight boards disappeared into the ground and four goal posts at each end arose vertically to their full height.

A combination of booing and cheering broke out as two Australian Football League teams simultaneously burst through crepe paper banners onto the ground. The Brisbane Lions and the Geelong Cats made their way around the arena in packs in preparation for their early season exhibition pre-season game.

“Hmm. We'd better scram and get on with our training”, Alexander called out to Cathy as they started spreading their wings along with the rest of Team Providence who were preparing to flyaway.

“Good luck with your Birdsville competition next week!” Sandra yelled to Cathy as they both smiled. Troy strolled over to Sandra and together they watched the team of eight fliers spread their wings in formation and in a great flurry fly off into the sky.

The cricket crowd continued to file out through the exits of the six level stadium as football supporters entered. Troy and Sandra joined the throngs as they stepped onto the numerous wide escalators that made their descent down the side of the mountain.

They both decided that they should take a ferry back to Melbourne from the Bay Island so they took an escalator that headed for the marina. Most spectators usually took the tram-shuttles because they were faster and the escalators heading for that end of the island were packed. But it was still a nice sunny day so the ferry trip was more appropriate Troy thought to himself as their moving staircase meandered through native bushland as it made its way down the side of the mountain.

The sight of all those people descending from the various levels of the mountain enclosed stadium was always breathtaking. Further off in the distance Troy could see Team Providence going through their formation exercises high above Port Phillip Bay. Troy realised that the usual amount of pride depended on them doing well in their next competition the following week and that the disappearance of his television Frend would be history by then and not worth remembering. As they boarded the ferry Sandra turned to Troy.

“I could have sworn I saw your television Frend during the cricket Test”, Sandra muttered in a casual way and soft enough to be ignored by Troy. He replied by wondering whether Cathy had also seen the Frend.

“Oh yes ... ,” Sandra replied, “Cathy was the one who pointed her out to

me on that giant video screen. How did you know her name was Mavis?”

Troy sat down on a long bench on the main deck of the medium sized ferry. Cricket followers shuffled past in search of other seats as Troy wondered what he should say. He doubted whether Sandra knew that he had visited the Bungle Bungle Ranges the previous day and had met the woman in the flesh whose image appeared on his television Frend.

“Well I asked her one day”, Troy said quickly trying to clear up the matter, “I said to the television Frend in the corner of our lounge room, 'what is your real name?' and the Frend said to me, 'My name is Mavis.' Now do you understand?” Troy whispered in anger. Sandra shifted around uncomfortably in her seat.

“Alright”, she replied trying to retreat from an argument, “it was silly of me to ask.”

The ferry pulled away from the Bay Island and headed for the Melbourne docklands. There was a medium chop on the water and the waves splashed against the hull of the old fashioned ferry as Troy continued the discussion with his wife Sandra.

“Anyway, she was probably someone who looked like Mavis”, he argued quietly, “the Frend is gone, finished, no more! We can forget about it”, Troy said as he encouraged Sandra to enjoy the ferry trip.

The Bay Island was now about two kilometres away. From a distance it began to resemble a tropical island with a volcanic mountain at the centre. The abundant red escalators criss-crossing the exterior of the mountain looked like streams of lava. Troy wondered about the surprise of sighting Mavis at the cricket. At any rate it was the last time he would see her for awhile.

Sandra was obviously keen to have domestic life return to normal and was pleased to see this happen with pace.

Setting the dials for dinner, controlling the temperature of the house, answering the phone and a myriad of other functions were now back in the hands of the family. There was no television Frend in the corner to handle all these things that made up day to day living. In fact Sandra was relieved to see that her family had completely forgotten the Frend after its disappearance.

Chapter 14

It wasn't long before Troy was packing his suitcases with the extra essentials for his forthcoming visit to the land of absurd weather where Team Providence would be competing against all the other top fliers and the Rainbow Lorikeets.

Troy had three large suitcases spread out around his bedroom as he packed numerous items. In went the big folded spacious tent, gum boots, raincoat, umbrellas, heavy weather gear, thick fake fur body-length overcoat, cumbersome oversized woollen gloves, ear muffs, summer tee-shirts, bathers, thongs and piles of other essentials.

He planned to spend a few days watching the flying so he wanted to be absolutely certain he was well prepared. On the way to Birdsville he would also be able to meet some other business commitments so he added his briefcase as the station porter wheeled them along the platform of Flinders Street station.

Within a minute Troy was zooming through the outskirts of Melbourne at high speed for his first destination of Canberra, the Capital of Australia. His most favoured business associate was always Albert who was busy finalising matters in the boardroom carriage of the Extremely Fast Train.

By the time the Eft had passed the mid-point of its journey Albert had completed his meeting and he walked along the train to Troy's carriage that was full of tourists and assorted business people. With the mist covered Mt. Kosciusko in view and other snowy mountains whizzing by Albert sat down next to Troy and ordered a cup of macchiato from the carriage steward.

"So in the end you didn't have a choice in keeping your Friend, it just disappeared?" Albert asked after summing up the dilemma Troy had just explained.

"That's right. And we're all pretty happy about it though. But I would be interested to know where it is", Troy said as Alexander handed him some papers and documents, "what are these?" he asked sensing an unease in Albert.

"They are more reports on the television Friend. And they seem to tally up with my own recent experience", Albert said in a worried and irritated tone of voice.

Troy hadn't spoken to Albert for two weeks so he was unaware of any recent experiences Albert may have had. He knew that Albert had had a television Friend installed in the reception area of his consultancy firm and he wondered if this was related to Alberts solemn tone.

“As you know I had some work commitments in Europe and I was away from my office for two weeks. Well when I arrived back and went into my office it was completely vacant”, Albert lamented looking seriously at Troy, “my television Frend had taken it upon itself to sell the business and all its contents. There was nothing left except a large carton of loose change that amounted to the worth of my business sitting on the floor in my empty office.”

“What did you do?” Troy enquired sympathetically.

“Well naturally I had my Frend taken away and completely dismantled by the Frend Corporation. Then I had to set up my business all over again. Re-employ my office staff, buy new office furniture and fittings and try and explain it away to my former clients”, Albert bemoaned.

Troy could believe all of this. Though he did wonder how the Frend managed to do it.

“Surely one of your secretaries must have tried to ring you in Europe and ask why you were selling up?” Troy enquired diplomatically.

“She did! Except the Frend evidently intercepted the call and imitated my voice. So the staff had my word, even though it wasn't me, and the sale went ahead”, Albert said regretfully.

For Troy this was the straw that broke the camels back. He would definitely have his television Frend returned and dismantled. All he needed to do was find it. And the ways things were going this was unlikely.

“Why do you think your Frend decided to sell off your business?” Troy asked Albert as the Eft sped through Yass and veered off towards the outskirts of Canberra.

“Well I got my staff back together again, a few of them anyway, and we went over the events in the office prior to my trip to Europe. Suddenly we remembered that we'd had a moderately big argument over petty cash”, Albert explained, “and one of my secretaries accused the television Frend of failing to have enough petty cash on hand.”

“So your Frend reduced your business to petty cash? That's amazing business acumen”, Troy said oscillating between laughter and seriousness.

“That's right. In the end all I had was one big sum of petty cash and nothing else. No business, no staff, no furniture, no nothing, just a large box of loose change and of course the television Frend sitting there with a smirk on its screen”, Albert concluded as they both went silent and gazed out the carriage window.

The train started to slow down as it approached the base of Black Mountain where the Parliament was now located. There were a number of towers similar to the Black Mountain Tower and all of these housed the Federal government, opposition and senior public servants.

The Eft pulled into the Black Mountain Tower station and a few people stepped off. Then it moved on and snaked its way around Black Mountain and headed for Capital Hill.

Long ago the Australian Parliament had moved from its grand sight in Capital Hill to the even grander and much higher cluster of towers on the top of Black Mountain that overlooked the city of Canberra.

The old New Parliament House was now used by a burgeoning Public Service that crammed thousands of workers into the corridors and offices. It was here that Troy and Albert had a couple of meetings arranged.

The Eft zoomed under Lake Burley Griffin and then smoothly made its way towards the Capital Hill station that was situated under the huge flag pole that was now covered in assorted satellite dishes, television aerials and numerous other communications apparatus. Other than the railway line and a few jogging paths the hill was completely covered in thick native bushland. The large front courtyard with its huge entrance was an open car park and soon slid out of sight as the Eft came to a standstill on the peak of Capital Hill.

Troy and Albert stepped from their carriage and strolled over to the lift that took them down into the bustling Members Gallery where they met some other business associates and adjourned to their offices for the meetings. The whole place was terribly overcrowded with public servants and the atmosphere was very claustrophobic. Troy was keen to get the engagements over with so he could head off to watch the flying.

He didn't have long to wait. The second meeting he attended with Albert was cancelled after one of the public servants involved fainted from overwork and exhaustion. After saying farewell to Albert, Troy was soon back on the Capital Hill station platform awaiting the arrival of another Extremely Fast Train to take him onto Sydney then Queensland.

The next Eft pulled up on the summit of Capital Hill and Troy stepped on board. He was more than pleased to escape the stifling conditions of the overcrowded old New Parliament House and his business commitments were now behind him.

Soon the Eft was speeding silently through the Blue Mountains after a brief stop in Sydney making its way along the Great Dividing Range towards

Queensland.

In Brisbane Troy caught another train that headed inland for the Great Artesian Basin to the Channel Country where the flying championships were taking place. It was a long five hour journey inland and Troy had plenty of time to unwind and enjoy the trip.

Most of the other passengers in Troy's carriage were also attending the same event so there was a lot of discussion about the forthcoming absurd weather conditions that their destination was famous for.

Chapter 15

Just outside Birdsville quarter way through the twenty-first century a new town had been built to create and study meteorological conditions. Adjacent to the Diamantina River this town had technological facilities installed that meant any weather condition could be created at a push of a button.

Here scientists and other specialists could study and experience climate variations at close range. It was also a popular destination for tourists, business conventions and in this case sporting carnivals.

There was an atmosphere of excited anticipation as the train pulled into the Birdsville station. Snow was falling and the ground was covered in a white sheet as Troy wheeled his three large suitcases along the platform. Suddenly the snow stopped and the sun came out melting the snow and causing a slushy mess underfoot.

Troy hailed a taxi truck and was soon driving through a small city of tents that accommodated most of the flying teams, spectators, press and officials. The clear sky was filled with flying teams who were not only training but also trying to acclimatise to the variable weather conditions.

Troy was halfway through the erection of his spacious tent on his prescribed camp site when there was a loud swishing of wings above him and looking up he could see Team Providence circling down to land nearby. Alexander gracefully landed first and folded back his wings as he strolled over to assist Troy.

“We spotted your colourful tent from miles up there”, Alexander said as he helped Troy pull the tent into position and tighten the guy ropes.

“How's your preparation been going?” Troy enquired as the rest of Team Providence landed and helped around the camp site.

“Just excellent as usual Troy”, Cathy replied, “nothing can stop us now.”

On that comment a dark cloud drifted over and placed them in a shadow. Suddenly there was a heavy downpour of rain. Troy's tent was large enough for all of them to huddle in.

“The land of absurd weather is living up to expectations. Any problems with lightning bolts?” Troy asked as he looked up into the storm clouds to witness a flash of lightning and then hear a loud peal of thunder echo around the area.

“Lightning bolts are always a problem”, Alexander answered as he pushed

his hand through the tent flap and watched it quickly fill with rain water. Team Providence were all very jovial and enjoyed the company of Troy.

“Where's Sandra?” Cathy enquired.

“She's got a lot of work on at the moment but will most likely arrive for the finals”, Troy said as he opened a wide umbrella and stepped out into the heavy downpour. The rain became hail and small lumps of ice splashed onto the sodden ground and made little indentations on the tents surface. Alexander looked closely at the hail.

“Right oh everyone. These are the conditions we want, so let's go”, he said as the team stepped out of the tent and spread their wings. Seconds later they took off and disappeared into the storm clouds high above the tent city.

Troy continued arranging his camp site. He folded out the table and chairs inside one section of the tent and started shuffling through one of the large suitcases in search of his swimming trunks and sunglasses. Troy was quite familiar with the weather patterns and he knew that soon it would be hot and sunny for awhile.

Like clockwork the rain stopped and the storm clouds drifted away. The sun came out causing steam to waft off the ground. Troy changed into his bathers and favourite summer t-shirt with 'I'm between a rock and a hard place' printed on it which Team Providence had produced to sell to spectators. Before long Troy was stretched out horizontally in his hammock enjoying the summer conditions.

This was the sort of thing Troy really liked. Not a problem in the world as he sipped on an ice-cold can of beer and surveyed the multitude of flyers training overhead. Not far from his relaxed disposition was a clearing and on the other side of that were a number of brightly coloured tents and he wondered what team was camped there as it was vacant of human activity.

Troy did have a theory though as the tents were poorly erected and their washing was strewn around the site. Deck chairs were scattered around and a half-eaten pig wallowed on the spit above the sodden camp fire. Unclean plates and dishes lay in disarrayed piles as a stray dog wandered amongst the food scraps.

A mist started to slowly drift through the tents. Gradually this turned into a heavy fog which made the area look rather mysterious and blocked out the view of the numerous flyers training above.

The temperature was still warm to hot and the atmosphere felt humid as Troy could hear a flapping of wings somewhere near. He looked up into the

dense fog and wondered which team it would be.

It was the Rainbow Lorikeets. Troy could just see some green wings through the fog. Then the reds, yellows and blues on their chests as the team of eight flyers ascended in a scattered formation and landed awkwardly on the clearing nearby.

“Come on, clean up this site”, one of Lorikeets demanded as they folded in their wings and took off their back-packs. Another Lorikeet member strolled across the clearing and approached Troy.

“Hullo Troy. Are you our next door neighbour?” he said in a friendly manner. Troy wasn't that enthusiastic about being so close to the Team Lorikeets nest because of their attitude problems and the fact that they were well down on the pecking order of flying teams. What's more, it had only been a few weeks since they and Team Rocks had hounded himself and Albert on the observation deck of the old Sydney Tower.

“Are you going to dazzle us with some new choreography?” Troy enquired, “any surprises in store?”

The Lorikeet member laughed and strolled back to his site before casting a glance over his shoulder at Troy.

“One surprise anyway”, quipped the Lorikeet as he disappeared into his tent laughing.

The fog began to drift away and the sky became clear again. Troy grabbed his binoculars and gazed up into the sky to study the various teams flying around. Directly above were the King Parrots and further over were the successful White-Faced Herons. Swooping low over the tent city as the fog all but disappeared were the Gang-Gang Cockatoos with their distinctive red curled feathers on their heads. Higher still Troy could make out the teams of Blue Wrens and Australian Kestrels.

Troy continued to gaze at the various teams going through their final preparations before the championships began in earnest. He then panned his binoculars across the tent city and watched five hot air balloons drift up into the sky.

In the baskets hanging below these balloons were crammed various officials and judges. Their job was to watch each of the teams and then give a score which was passed onto the officials on the ground in the large marquee that housed the electronic scoreboard.

An official on a bicycle peddled up the path and stopped next to Troy who

was still gazing at the spectacle of all the flyers in the sky.

“Hey Troy, Alexander told me you were here. Do you want to come up in one of the balloons?” he asked pointing towards the five balloons drifting over the tent city.

“Certainly do”, Troy said as he sprang from his hammock enthusiastically, “the closer the better.” He grabbed his jumper and coat and followed the official down the path.

A second group of hot air balloons was about to take off. These baskets contained some officials but mainly spectators and press. Troy clambered into one of the baskets as the blasts of burning gas filled the balloon and the gondola lifted off the ground. From this aerial vantage point Troy got a wonderful birds eye view of the tent city.

Troy could clearly see his own tent and the group of tents nearby housing the Rainbow Lorikeets. Near the centre of the city he could see the pristine tents that accommodated Team Providence. They had an excellent position on the banks of the Diamantina River because they were on top of the pecking order. The crack New South Wales flappers Team Rocks had their Opera House shaped tent nearby which was the talking point of the tent city. They held down the second position in the pecking order and were always a threat to Team Providence.

The hot air balloon continued to rise up into the atmosphere. The press photographer standing next to Troy fixed his telephoto lens on the main building that actually housed all the meteorological equipment that controlled the ever changing weather in this area.

“It's my bet we'll get heavy fog again”, said the photographer as a dense cloud of fog started to pour out of the pipes around the tent city. There was no set pattern to the weather that was served up by the meteorological scientists. In fact they went out of their way to give as much variety as possible.

Soon the entire tent city was enveloped in dense fog and nothing on the ground could be seen. Above the fog Troy watched various teams flying around and further afield he could see the dry uninhabited plains of the Channel Country that was unaffected by the weather variations taking place below him.

The hot air balloon drifted along in the still sunshine. From out of the dense fog below three teams of flyers winged their way up and one of them was Team Providence. They had to perform a flying formation of their own choice and Team Providence had nominated the very difficult spiral formation. It looked quite easy in many ways but the flyers always found it tricky because

once one or more flyers got out of formation they found it hard to get back into it. Nevertheless they had achieved perfection in this event many times and that was why they sat on top of the pecking order.

Everyone thought the current event would be held above the dense fog but the meteorological scientists had more ambitious plans and they were concocting a pretty decent thunderstorm. So the fog made way for dark threatening storm clouds.

“This will test their meta?’, the photographer commented to Troy with an edge of apprehension. It was all very jolly sailing along in a hot air balloon above fine mist or dense fog but having a thunderstorm rage around them made the gondola sway and observation dim.

Team Rocks with their emerald-coloured wings had the honour of performing first in the formation flying and had nominated the 'V' Formation which was similar to the usual flight of real birds. They swung into their flight pattern and although the rain started to pelt down and the wind buffeted their almost luminous wings they swooped past the hot air balloon Troy was in and were rewarded high marks by the judges.

Further afield Team Providence seemingly dived upwards out of the thick dark clouds and began their difficult formation. In the single file followed by the team Alexander flew in fourth position just ahead of Cathy. The sound of thunder started to grumble through the storm clouds.

As Team Providence spiralled along confidently Alexander noticed from his peripheral vision a solo flyer winging its way towards them. Alexander lost sight of it as he flew upside-down at the bottom of the spiral before arcing over where once again he noticed a solo flyer coming closer and closer to them as they surged forward in a concentrated spiral formation.

Troy had his binoculars fixed on the team. He didn't like the claps of thunder resounding around the gondola which was swaying more actively than before nor did he like the sight of the solo flyer he recognised as a Rainbow Lorikeet. There was worse to come because Troy also identified something else that sent a cold shiver down his spine.

Alexander meanwhile tried to watch both his team and the aerial predator and he found the dual responsibilities very challenging. Further ahead he spotted some lightning bolts jumping from the dark storm clouds. Nevertheless the formation continued with perfect timing and masterful precision until suddenly the solo flyer loomed up only metres from Team Providence. It was so close that Alexander had to take his eyes off his team and look squarely at this

dangerous distraction.

It was a Rainbow Lorikeet team member treading air right in front of them and clutching the television Friend. Alexander could clearly see it was Troy's television Friend being held by the laughing Lorikeet. The beautiful woman on the screen looked horrified and screamed out to Team Providence.

"HELP! Help me!" she cried out in fear and panic, "I might be dropped!"

"Is this what you're looking for?" yelled the Lorikeet member as he suddenly nose-dived holding the Friend and swooped down under Team Providence. He disappeared through a dark storm cloud and was gone. Only his laughter lingered as another clap of thunder resounded from the terrible weather.

The scare took seconds to unfold but was enough for Alexander to lose his formation and he swung out too wide as Team Providence spiralled along. He managed to regain his position but the damage was done. The judges had noticed and the team would lose valuable points, maybe even enough to knock them from the top of the pecking order.

Troy stood silently in the basket of the hot air balloon. He had focused his binoculars on the Lorikeet and had clearly sighted the image of Mavis on the screen of the television Friend being held captive by the flying predator. Troy knew exactly what was going on and he was far from impressed.

Team Providence completed their flight and glided down through the dark clouds towards their tents and hovered in slightly dishevelled and landed.

They moped around for a moment then folded in their wings and took off their back-packs in disgust. Alexander was unusually lost for words. He averted his gaze from the rest of the team and stared at the wet ground. Cathy suggested they do some relaxation exercises and then sit down and have a team chat. It was important to clarify their thoughts and plan a strategy for winning. Also there was the minor problem of the actual television Friend.

"The fact of the matter is Alexander, this could go on forever", Cathy whispered to Alexander who had his head in his hands in despair, "until this thing is dismantled it could keep springing up in front of us for god knows how long. I just don't know what got into Troy's head. We told him at the beginning that these Friends were lethal", Cathy continued to confide to Alexander, "and poor Troy ... he must be feeling just awful up there."

Troy was feeling just awful. The storm was raging around his balloon and

the basket was swaying back and forth violently as thunder claps cracked around them high above the tent city.

“You know something?” the photographer said looking on in pity at Troy, “I was looking at all that action and I could swear I saw actual bolts of lightning coming out of that television being held by the Lorikeet...”

Troy caressed his worried forehead. He had noticed the same thing. He also wondered how Alexander and Team Providence were feeling. In reality he was aware he had caused the whole problem in the first place. Heavy rain was still falling and water was streaming down the side of the hot air balloon and splashing on his head and Troy felt really miserable.

Way down in the Team Providence tent the flyers sat in a huddle and discussed the awkward situation they found themselves in. They definitely decided it was no good protesting against the Lorikeets because that would just make them the centre of attention and everyone would be impressed by the audacity of their stunt. Furthermore, flyers were always confronted by endless diversions in the air and it was all part of the art of flight.

There's nothing here in the rule book that says you can't flap around with a television”, Cathy said as she thumbed through the thick manual on the laws of flying.

“Anyway, the judges will laugh in our face if we protest about this one”, Alexander concluded as he looked out the tent and noticed the rain had stopped. They all decided to have lunch and concentrate their efforts on the speed events.

The storm clouds drifted away and the sun came out. Once again steam wafted from the surface of the Birdsville ground as it slowly dried.

Chapter 16

Troy climbed out of the basket of the hot air balloon and strolled back in the direction of his tent. With his hands in his pockets he shuffled along in a dispirited manner. He wondered how he would retrieve his television Frend, if ever.

The path took him past many of the tents accommodating various teams. He tried not to look up and exchange glances with the numerous competitors. The team of Flying Lizards from the Northern Territory went silent as Troy walked by. The sun shone down hard on him, the air became even more humid and he felt like he was stepping on flypaper.

Finally he reached his tent. He had to walk past the colourful tents of the Rainbow Lorikeets and he could hear muffled giggles and suppressed laughter from within. Troy wanted to collect his thoughts before he confronted them to demand the return of his television Frend. But he didn't need to because when he opened the flap it revealed the television Frend sitting in the corner of his tent.

Troy sat down and looked at it. His eyes blinked in slow motion and his heart beat slightly faster.

"Switch on please Frend", Troy said after a resigned sigh. The television flickered on and presented the beautiful young woman he now knew as Mavis.

"Hullo Troy! It's good to see you again!" the Frend said politely and happily showing no signs of the adventure she had been through. Her smile was as warm as ever and for Troy it was strange to see her on the screen again having met her in the flesh as Mavis when he went to the Frend Corporation headquarters in the Bungle Bungles.

He also felt a strong emotional attachment with her because after all that had happened between them the bond was rather powerful. So he couldn't bring himself to be angry with her either. Most probably in the back of his mind Troy wanted an excuse to see Mavis again. The night he had spent with her was one of his more pleasurable experiences.

"I'm afraid I'm going to take you back to the Frend Corporation and have you dismantled ... I'm sorry", Troy said as he gazed into the television screen.

For a split second her eyes twinkled and a sensuous smile flashed across her face. Then it crumpled and a tear rolled down her cheek. She took a handkerchief from her sleeve and clutched it.

"I understand Troy. Would you mind if the Vice-President of the Frend

Corporation spoke to you please?” she said plaintively before disappearing from the screen to be replaced by the affable Vice-President seated at his desk. His eyebrows were raised in anticipation as he addressed Troy.

“Hullo Mr. Day, how are you? It's good to see you so well. Would you like me to send down one of my assistants to pick up your television Frend and take it away... “ he said before pausing for a moment, “ ... or would you like to bring it here yourself? “ He leaned forward on his desk and smile pleasantly as if he knew the answer already.

“No no ...” Troy replied defensively, “I'll bring it up to the corporation personally. I want it dismantled and I want to see it done myself.”

“Right you are”, said the Vice-President with a broad smile, “you know what's best. We are only here to serve your best interests.” He disappeared from the screen and was replaced by the beautiful young woman. She still appeared to be upset but was trying to put on a brave face.

“I'm looking forward to seeing you again up here Troy”, she said sniffing a bit.

The tent flap was suddenly flung open and Alexander and Cathy strode in angrily. The atmosphere became tense as they both stared at the television in the corner of Troy's tent. For a moment there was a deafening silence. The Frend then decided to break the ice.

“Hullo there Alexander and Cathy ... “ said the television Frend nervously stuffing her handkerchief back into her sleeve, “I'm terribly sorry I distracted you all up there in your formation flying but I didn't have any choice”, the Frend continued innocently, “your flying is very impressive at close hand. Watching your Team Providence go through the formation flying thing stopped me thinking about my vertigo!

“Cut the drivel”, Cathy replied furiously, “we're not about to let a pile of technological junk stop us from winning. Now switch off and shut your face!” snapped Cathy as the screen went blank instantly.

“I'm sorry”, Alexander said turning to Troy, “but we've slipped to second place and we can't afford anymore mishaps.”

“I understand. I know”, Troy replied quickly, “I'm going to personally take it back to the Frend Corporation and have it dismantled. No more television Frend. All gone. Finished.”

That wasn't enough for Cathy. She was seething with total anger and her fists were clenched tightly in fury as she blurted out her plan of action.

“We're going to smash it to pieces right here and now and be done with it”, Cathy said fuming away.

The confrontation halted when they heard the sound of muffled laughter outside the tent. Alexander opened the tent flap and standing buckled over outside were three members of the Rainbow Lorikeets. Their faces were slightly contorted as they tried to hold down a convulsion of laughter. One of them managed to hold out a cheap rubber mallet for hammering in tent pegs and he put on a poker face as he spoke in a mock serious tone.

“Here, you can borrow this”, he said before they quickly turned and fled back into their team tent which had erupted into uncontrollable laughter.

Alexander looked at their colourful tent with its rainbow stripes and made no comment. Meanwhile Troy was frantically searching through one of his suitcases for the train time-table which he couldn't find. Alexander turned around and looked at the television Frend.

“Switch on Frend”, he commanded as the television Frend flickered on and the beautiful woman looked at him attentively.

“Yes Alexander, what can I do for you?” she asked politely.

“When does the next train leave for the Kimberleys?” he demanded.

“A train leaves in thirty two minutes”, she replied.

“Thankyou. Now switch off”, he said as the screen went blank again.

Troy emptied one of his large suitcases and they lifted the television Frend into it and shut the lid. Before long they were loading the suitcase into a taxi and were driving out of the tent city.

The sunshine had long gone and light snow was falling as the taxi pulled up outside the Birdsville railway station. Troy was very apologetic about the whole episode and he promised he would not let the suitcase containing the television Frend out of his sight.

Alexander and Cathy waved to Troy from the snow covered railway platform as the train started its journey up north.

Chapter 17

Troy sat silently in his seat in a near empty train carriage gazing out the window. In the distance he could just make out all the activity in the sky where the flying competition was going on. The hot air balloons drifted around some clouds and the various flyers were now just dots above the horizon which gave Troy the feeling of lonely detachment.

With his large suitcase resting on the seat next to him he at least knew that the television Frend could not cause anymore problems for Team Providence. More than likely they would soon regain the top position in the pecking order of flying teams.

Once out of the Channel Country the train would make its way through Mt. Isa then across the Barkly Tableland to the Kimberleys where the Bungle Bungle Ranges were located that housed the Frend Corporation. It was not an extremely fast train Troy was travelling on but a restored red rattler from the previous century so the journey would take a good six hours.

Troy looked around his virtually empty carriage and was surprised to recognise the elderly couple that had been on his trip to Sydney some weeks before. He recalled how Albert and himself were busily discussing the installation of his television Frend and the elderly couple had mentioned that in their suburb of Hobart Tasmania the local council had the television Frends banned because they caused too much trouble and he had shrugged off the advice.

Troy wondered if they would remember him and whether he should tell them they were right and that he was on his way to have the Frend dismantled. Eventually he caught their eye and they exchanged a friendly wave. Then the elderly couple walked up the aisle and sat on the seats opposite Troy.

“This is a coincidence seeing you two again”, Troy said smiling.

“Yes it is. We're on the final stages of our mainland holiday so we're touring the centre of Australia”, the gentleman said, “and we're so surprised at the amount of vegetation. We thought the centre was mainly desert like it used to be.”

“Well once we solved the problem of turning saltwater into freshwater there was no holding back the green movement”, Troy explained warming to the pleasure of the conversation.

They all gazed out the window of the train for awhile. Large tracts of dense forest passed by intersected by numerous irrigation streams. The elderly man

laughed at his own thought.

“It's certainly lucky water flows down hill because there's no shortage of saltwater in the Arafura Sea”, he said nudging his wife playfully. Then he looked slightly puzzled.

“Could you tell me why you've got your big suitcase right next to you and not in the baggage carriage?” he enquired at the urging of his wife.

Troy wasn't sure if he felt like telling them the real reason. But then he decided it was a long journey to the Kimberleys and they had exchanged their opinions on television Friends before so there probably wasn't any harm in continuing the discussion.

“Well as a matter of fact inside this suitcase is my television Friend which I'm returning to its maker”, Troy said summing up the actual situation. The elderly couple looked surprised and even slightly intimidated by the answer.

Nothing was said for some time. The elderly couple then started arguing quietly amongst themselves. Troy wasn't sure what they were arguing about but he had a fair idea because they kept glancing nervously at the suitcase. Finally resisting the protests of the husband the elderly wife approached Troy.

“Did you have any problems with it?” she enquired. Troy laughed and decided to tell them all the different catastrophes that had befallen him since installing the Friend. The elderly couple nodded in interest as Troy's tale unfolded.

“So there you have it. You mentioned last time we met that the Friends were banned in your suburb ... why was that?” Troy asked. The elderly couple looked a bit embarrassed. Their eyes portrayed their minds searching for the right words to give an answer. But no explanation was forthcoming. They all stared out the window for awhile. Then the couple started whispering to each other finally coming to an agreement.

“The television Friends were very popular in our neighbourhood”, explained the husband, “then one day all the sets sort of inter-connected with each other and simultaneously broadcast an urgent newsflash announcing that an enormous forty foot tall anthropoid ape had escaped from the Hobart Zoo and was crushing and killing its way around the suburbs! Anyway everybody believed it”, the husband lamented and his wife blushed.

“I suppose there was no reason why they shouldn't”, Troy replied sympathetically.

“Well there was actually because the Hobart Zoo doesn't have a forty foot

high anthropoid ape. It doesn't have any gorillas at all", the elderly gentleman explained patiently, "anyway the widespread panic caused all sorts of headaches. The images on the screen looked so real."

"The number of heart attacks recorded in our suburb immediately after the newsflash was higher than the previous ten years combined!" said the wife, "and there were suicides, stampedes and utter chaos for hours afterwards!"

"Why do you think the television Frennds got together and did this newsflash?" Troy enquired curiously as the elderly couple looked at each other again in embarrassment. Finally the husband gave an answer.

"Well the Hobart Zoo does have an enclosure for small chimpanzees and one of our neighbours used to feed them bananas on a regular basis. Anyway he thought they were so gregarious and intelligent that he donated the zoo a television Frend which they put in the chimpanzees enclosure", the husband said as he wiped the perspiration from his forehead, "to keep them entertained."

"So do you think the television Frend was making some sort of statement on behalf of the chimps?" Troy enquired.

"Yes", the wife quickly interjected, "the chimps thought the bananas were not good enough!"

There was a moment of thought between the three of them. The couple still warily shot glances at the suitcase next to Troy. The train started to slow down and came to a standstill at the Mt. Isa railway station.

Suddenly the elderly husband stood up and announced that he and his wife were getting off at this station and they shuffled down the aisle and out the carriage door without even saying goodbye.

The train moved off again. It was a long and monotonous journey as Troy dozed off for a couple of hours. The trip was conducive to sleep and Troy had a dream as the red rattler made its way through the Northern Territory.

He slept through the brief stop at Tennant Creek and continued his dream as the train made its way across the Tanami Desert rolling through the Walmanpa-Waripiri Aboriginal Land where the vegetation was scarce.

Troy dreamed about the Frend, the image of Mavis and Mavis herself. He dreamed he was flying with Mavis and his dream climaxed when they embraced in the air. He felt a hand on his shoulder shaking him and he awoke to see Mavis standing there in front of him.

"Wake up Troy, it's me, Mavis!" she said with a warm smile. His eyes blinked and he momentarily couldn't decide whether he was dreaming or he was

awake.

“What are you doing here?” Troy asked as he slowly regained his orientation and realised she was real.

“What are you doing here I should ask”, Mavis replied as Troy looked a bit embarrassed.

“Well to be honest I'm taking my television Frend back to the Frend Corporation to have it dismantled ... is that alright?” Troy asked not wanting to offend her.

“Of course it is. Listen, I was just on my way to the restaurant carriage. Do you want to come along for lunch?” she said taking him by the hand.

Troy was hoping to see Mavis when he arrived at the Bungle Bungles so to see her before he got there was even better he thought to himself.

Troy and Mavis soon found themselves comfortably seated at a table in the restaurant carriage of the train as it rumbled across the desert. Outside the window there was virtually nothing as far as the eye could see. Some vast areas of Australia had been left completely untouched and were not thickly vegetated as was possible. The restaurant carriage was about half full and a few waiters went about their business in an efficient way.

“This isn't some kind of mediocre buffet car”, the waiter said to Troy proudly, “this is quality a la carte cuisine. The best food you'll get in this area”, he said happily as he handed them both a menu. They gave their orders and chose a fine Northern Territory red wine as the waiter lit the candle on their table. Pleasant classical music was played by a flautist and violinist moving amongst the diners.

“This is just perfect”, Troy said as he held her hand across the table, “and incidentally, were you at the cricket recently at the Bay Island ...?”

“Yes! It was a great piece of bowling. I had a few days holiday so I thought I'd watch some of the demolition at the Test. I had front row seats!”, Mavis said laughing.

“Well I saw you there. Did you know that? But I was on the top level of the stadium so I couldn't talk to you”, Troy mentioned cautiously as the waiter uncorked a Katherine Gorge bottle of red wine and poured them each a glass. Another waiter arrived and placed their meals on the table.

Outside the window of the restaurant carriage some kangaroos hopped past as Troy and Mavis chatted away. They both realised that they clearly enjoyed each others company and although Troy was about to have his television Frend

dismantled he was thankful he had got it in the first place because it was through the Friend that he had met Mavis. And although he was happily married to Sandra, his affair with Mavis was giving him a new lease of life and a fresh dimension to his middle age.

“Do you think we'll keep seeing each other after I have the Friend dismantled?” Troy wondered aloud to Mavis.

“I hope so”, Mavis replied, “I mean it's only my image on the screen of that thing. I'm still me. I can't see anything that should prevent us from meeting discreetly...” she replied quietly.

“Love is a sacred ... “ 'thing' Troy was about to say when there was a massive jolt like the train had hit a wall. In fact it was screeching to a halt as everything in the train flew forward. Plates of food, waiters, musicians and anything else that wasn't tied down was flung forward in a chaotic mess. The metal wheels of the train screeched into reverse before the train stopped and started moving in the opposite direction. Passengers and baggage were thrown onto the floor. Mavis's spaghetti bolognese narrowly missed Troy and splattered over the diners on the next table. A la carte cuisine was airborne along with knives and forks as cries of shock and horror filled the carriage. Bottles and glasses rolled down the aisle. The waiter was thrown on his face.

“What the hell has happened!?” Troy yelled over the groans and shrieks of other passengers thrown forward like crash-test dummies.

“Don't panic!” screamed one of the waiters as he got up from the floor and headed towards the train engine. Troy untangled himself from Mavis and the tablecloth thrown over him by the sudden halt and followed the waiter towards the engine room.

By now the train was slowly gathering speed in the opposite direction while Troy stepped over a mess of passengers and food and managed to clamber through the carriage door into the engine room next door. The driver was in shock and madly pointing at the small monitor next to the control panel.

“IT'S COMING THIS WAY!!” he screamed at Troy and the waiter.

“What is?” Troy yelled back in the pandemonium.

“For gods sake LOOK!” the train driver screamed back hysterically as he pointed at the monitor. Troy gazed at the small television monitor that showed what was on the track further ahead.

A huge serpent-like monster was pounding its way along the train track tearing apart everything in its path. Troy went cold with fear. Urgently he

peered out the front window of the train engine now pushing the carriages in reverse. But he could see nothing. The track was clear.

Troy stuck his head out of the side window and with the driver's binoculars searched the railway track. It was completely clear and there was nothing but parallel metal tracks stretching as far as the eye could see. Yet on the small monitor a serpent monster was devouring and destroying the railway line as it pounded along menacingly with frightening intent.

Troy had a fair idea what was happening as he tried to calm the driver and waiter who were both quivering in fear.

"There's nothing out there! It's an illusion, a mirage created on your monitor. Do you understand?" Troy said as he made his way out of the engine room and back into the restaurant carriage.

Diners and waiters were still picking themselves off the floor as Troy pushed his way through. He grabbed Mavis by the hand and kept scrambling along the aisle and into the next carriage half full of passengers sprawled out in a tangled mess of confusion. Finally they arrived back at the carriage where Troy had originally been seated.

This carriage was also in mayhem. In the sudden reversal of the direction of the train Troy's suitcase had been catapulted from its seat and broken open leaving the television Frend lying on the floor.

"Be calm everyone!" Troy assured the shaken passengers of the carriage as he lifted the television Frend onto the seat and sat down opposite it with Mavis alongside.

"Would you be good enough to turn on please Frend ... ?" Troy enquired in a plaintive tone. The screen started to flicker on and finally revealed the beautiful young woman who was identical to Mavis. The other shaken passengers watched in momentary silence. A strange unease was created within the carriage.

"Hullo there Troy. How are you today?" the Frend asked in a jolly voice.

"Have you met Mavis?" Troy enquired.

"No... I haven't", the Frend replied politely, "hullo Mavis, how are you?"

"Hullo me", Mavis said with a small laugh. The other passengers in the carriage looked at each other. They were not sure what was going on. All they knew was that the train had suddenly screeched to a dramatic halt and was reversing along the railway track. Troy's eyebrows went into furrow mode.

"You didn't use your influence to win friends in the engine room did you?"

Troy asked the television. The beautiful woman on the screen looked concerned and determined.

“Well Troy ... I'm not that pleased about our journey to the Kimberleys. I don't really want to be dismantled at the Frend Corporation”, the Frend said in a matter of fact way. The other passengers looked confused.

“Now listen here Frend. I want you to make that serpent monster disappear from the train drivers monitor immediately”, Troy demanded angrily.

“Oh... alright”, the Frend said pursing her lips patiently.

In the engine room the driver was still panic stricken as he watched the monitor and could see the serpent gaining on the train as it raced along in reverse. Suddenly it vanished from the screen and the driver looked both surprised and relieved. He put the brakes on again and after the train stopped he placed it in forward and the train headed off in its original direction.

The curious passengers in the carriage stepped a bit closer to the television Frend to look at it. Meanwhile Mavis noticing the attention felt a bit embarrassed about seeing her image on the screen that looked like her, spoke like her but had an intelligence far in advance of her.

“There's no way we can actually switch you off completely unless we have you taken to pieces is there Frend?” Troy enquired warming to the situation he found himself in.

“No there's not Troy. I'm sorry”, replied the Frend politely.

“I see. Would you mind switching off in the meantime?” Troy said as the woman disappeared from the screen which went blank immediately. Troy lifted it back into his large suitcase and closed the lid. The other passengers returned to their seats and the train journey continued towards the Kimberleys. Troy and Mavis sat down together and gazed out the window as they surveyed the passing scenery.

Chapter 18

Sandra and her daughter Stacy sat at the kitchen table staring glumly into their respective cups of coffee. Stacy had returned home triumphantly from her drama season in the Antarctic only to be confronted with the news of how Troy's television Frend had become embroiled in a Rainbow Lorikeets stunt that had knocked Team Providence from the top of the pecking order in Birdsville.

Cathy had telephoned Sandra and informed her of every agonising detail of the event and how Troy had subsequently decided to personally courier the television Frend to the Frend Corporation to have it dismantled.

The drastic news had led their conversation into the often discussed perilous complications of life in the middle of the twenty first century.

"If only life was simpler", Stacy said as she accidentally dropped her biscuit into her coffee. The only shining light in the current shadow of dark news came from the evergreen twelve year old youngest son Chips. He and some of his classmates had won a free excursion to the Australian base on the Moon for producing the best papier-mâché solar system in the inter-school Astronomy class contest.

They had all at one time or another made the journey to the Mare Humorum area of the Moon where in the Doppelmayr crater the Australian base was situated. Originally established for research purposes it had soon been taken over by holiday developers and was a popular destination for would-be space adventurers who yearned for a taste of weightlessness but didn't want the excessively long trip to Mars.

At any rate Chips and a dozen of his classmates had blasted off into outer space and were having a great time playing astronauts aboard the Australian space-shuttle Endeavour as it headed for the Moon.

Everyone and their dog had at some stage taken a ride on the Endeavour and this time Chips took the family dog because certain pets were allowed to go along since dogs were the first space travellers anyway back in the middle of the twentieth century.

It was a four day round trip and they spent most of their time playing volleyball which was the most favoured way for filling in time. When other passengers wanted to use the volleyball court on the shuttle Chips made use of the various facilities for viewing Earth and phoning home.

So as Sandra and Stacy were chatting away around the kitchen table they

were not surprised when the phone rang and it was Chips on the line again.

“Come in Day headquarters. Do you read me?” Chips said putting on a serious astronaut voice.

“Yes hullo dear. Are you enjoying yourself?” Sandra enquired as she switched on the open line so Stacy could listen in also.

“Green light. A okay. Everything fine. Planet Earth looking good from here”, reported Chips.

“You mean yes do you?” Stacy asked finding the constant calls from Chips rather tedious and a distraction from her conversation with Sandra.

“What have you been doing up there? More volleyball?” Sandra enquired patiently.

“Not at the moment. We've already had over thirty games. I've been using the telescope”, Chips said.

“Seen anything this time?” Stacy asked.

“Well as a matter of fact I have seen something. I've been watching some of the flying at Birdsville when the weather is clear and I noticed something else”, Chips announced.

“What is that?” Sandra enquired detecting a serious tone in his voice.

“Well you know how you told me that Dad had taken the train north to have his Frennd dismantled?” Chips continued as Sandra and Stacy looked at each other, “well, I rang the railways and found out the train he must be on and I managed to locate it through this powerful telescope ... “ he said as his voice trailed off.

“So?” replied the two together.

“So I was looking at it as it made its way through the Northern Territory and suddenly it stopped and went into reverse for awhile then stopped again and went forward. It struck me as a bit odd. It seemed to stop so suddenly”, Chips explained.

“Okay then dear, thanks for that. You behave yourself up there and don't forget to feed the dog. Bye.” Sandra said as she hung up the phone.

It wasn't lost on Sandra that the observation made by Chips of Troy's train journey was a bit strange. After all, trains didn't normally change direction without a reason and Sandra was well aware of the baggage Troy was carrying. Sandra and Stacy sat in the kitchen thinking.

“Why don't you ring Albert?” Stacy brainstormed.

“Of course! That's a marvellous idea. He's been studying these Frends and is sure to know what to do”, Sandra said enthusiastically as she tapped out Alberts number on the telephone.

Albert was coincidentally attending a meeting with the Minister for Serious Problems in the brand new Parliament House Tower situated on the top of Black Mountain overlooking the city of Canberra. His mobile phone rang and he answered it.

“Yes?”

“Hullo Albert. It's Sandra here. I'm ringing from home”, she said.

“What can I do for you?” he enquired in his usual business-like manner.

“You know how Troy went to Birdsville to watch the flying? Well you'll never guess what, but his television Frend turned up in rather unfortunate circumstances in the hands of the Rainbow Lorikeets. Anyway, to cut a long story short, he decided to personally take it back to the Frend Corporation to have it dismantled, not before time in my opinion, and he's presently on the train with it now”, Sandra explained.

“That's good. So what's the problem?” Albert asked.

“Well from the information we have managed to gather, it appears the Frend is up to its old tricks again. This time playing havoc with the train ... “ Sandra said leaving the circumstances up to Alberts imagination.

“I see”, Albert replied, “leave it with me. I was just now discussing the Frend Corporation with the Minister. Thanks for the information. Bye”, Albert said as he put away his mobile phone and looked at the Minister, “Hmm. Still more problems with our Frend.”

The fact that the Frend Corporation had come to the attention of the Minister for Serious Problems meant that the government had decided to deal with the various mounting complaints at a top level. And you couldn't get much higher than the brand new Parliament House Tower.

The overcrowded old New Parliament House on Capital Hill had long ago been abandoned and left to the enormous public service that soon turned it into a bureaucratic ghetto. Many a fresh faced public servant had disappeared without trace into the overloaded and congested myriad of offices on Capital Hill. Indeed a day never went by without news of some poor bureaucrat dying from overwork or nervous exhaustion. Worse still was the current epidemic of public servants fainting in triplicate due to the crammed and stifling conditions.

The Minister strummed his fingers on his large desk of his spacious office

and looked at Albert.

“What should we do?” he asked Albert who was gazing out the window surveying Lake Burley Griffin. Albert had a few ideas but he wasn't about to mention them to the Minister who was notorious for making serious problems worse.

Albert watched some people jogging around the lake. From the tower they looked like ants with a lot of them milling around the National Art Gallery situated on the banks of Lake Burley Griffin.

The 'Minimalist Movement' that had swept the art world at the beginning of the twenty first century had seen all the paintings taken down from the walls of the art gallery leaving it completely barren. For decades now it had only been used as an indoor jogging track for public servants wearing colourful Ken Done t-shirts.

The Minister's secretary entered the office with tea and biscuits and Albert stopped gazing out the window and sat down on the comfortable couches around the low coffee table. The Minister seemed in despair.

“We can't offend the Frennd Corporation under any circumstances. Last week we decided to have the model returned that I had in this very office”, the Minister said pointing to the empty space in the corner.

“Did that go smoothly?” Albert enquired.

“Not really. Somehow the Frennd inter-connected with the extensive closed circuit security monitors throughout this Parliament House Tower and when I arrived for work the following morning all the security monitors showed me staggering along the corridors as if I was drunk. I had a party hat on, I was covered in streamers and confetti, I was blowing one of those paper whistles and a lot of the time I skipped and danced ... “ explained the Minister sorrowfully as he rubbed his forehead, “somehow the television Frennd manipulated my image on the security monitors. For all intensive purposes I appeared like some sort of drunken lunatic arriving at work. It was terrible.”

“What happened then?” Albert wondered aloud with his mouth agape.

“Well, when the security guards ran down to help me they found I was normally dressed, quite sober and arriving for work in my usual manner. They were astounded. The trouble was that everyone else watching the monitors didn't know the image was quite false. I've spent most of this week rejecting invitations for drinks in other offices. My reputation has been ruined.” the Minister lamented as he fell silent.

Albert started thinking about Troy again. He wondered how his journey to the Kimberleys was going. Would he in fact make it to the destination? Should he go there himself? How could these things be contained? He looked over at the Minister who started mumbling aloud.

“This is the most serious problem I've had since becoming Minister and it's far more serious than the problems I had last month and a lot worse than last years serious problems ... “ the Minister said as he stared blankly into his cup of tea.

Chapter 19

The red rattler shunted to a standstill at the Kimberley Central Station and the train driver breathed a sigh of relief. It was the worst experience he'd had on a journey across the Northern Territory for as long as he could remember. He looked on nervously as Troy wheeled his large suitcase containing the television Frend along the platform. The day was hot and sunny and a dusty wind blew through the station corridors.

Mavis was slightly apprehensive about returning to the Frend Corporation on account of the terrible malfunctions she had personally witnessed. But before long they were both seated in a taxi weaving its way through the Bungle Bungle Ranges with the large gates of the Frend Corporation looming up in front of them.

“When you get through the entrance turn right and drop us off at the dismantling depot thanks driver”, Mavis instructed the taxi driver. Having worked there for a few years she knew the layout of the plant and headquarters very well and had spent at least one year giving guided tours to prospective buyers and tourists in general.

Mavis even knew the best technician to oversee the great dismantling and so all in all Troy was pretty pleased that the whole episode was reaching a clear finality. He would be rid of his television Frend and would go out to dinner with Mavis afterwards to celebrate.

The fact that he was about to have the image of Mavis ended and yet still have the person the image was likened to as his dinner date in the flesh made him laugh and fortunately Mavis found the situation rather amusing too.

The taxi pulled up inside the dismantling depot and the whole magnitude of the problem became blatantly obvious. An enormous pile of television Frends confronted Troy. And the noise coming from the pile that stretched as far as the depot was long was deafening.

“There must be over five thousand television Frends piled up here ... and they're all switched on!” Troy said loudly to Mavis as they gazed in disbelief at the mountain of Frends.

At the other end of the depot Troy could see a conveyor belt that was channelling the sets to the dismantling area where they were being systematically taken apart. Various technicians in colourful coats with Frend Corporation emblazoned on them went about their business with a happy demeanour. One chap approached them with a smile.

“Hullo Mavis! How was your short holiday down south?” he asked giving an irritated glance at the pile of televisions.

“Pardon? I can hardly hear you!” Mavis said cupping her hand over her ear.

“Oh. Sorry”, the technician said as he turned angrily to the mountain of noisy televisions, “QUIETII SHUT UPII” he bellowed at the top of his voice. Instantly they went silent.

“That's better”, he continued, “What's this? Do you want to get this set done straight away?” he enquired as Troy helped him lift his television Frend onto a trolley.

“Yes, that would be very good of you. Troy here has been having more than enough problems with his Frend and wants to see it dismantled personally”, Mavis said.

“Fine by me. That's what we do all day here”, the technician said openly. Then he paused and looked at Troy. “I guess you'll be sorry to see this Frend go?”

Troy was a bit startled by the question. He looked down at the television Frend as it was wheeled along past the enormous wall of other sets who had all begun to murmur quietly amongst themselves.

“Go on Troy ... “ Mavis urged as they strolled towards the dismantling area, “at least say goodbye.”

“Oh alright then”, Troy replied as he gazed at the set, “switch on Frend so we can say our goodbyes.”

The television Frend flickered on and the beautiful young woman appeared on the screen wiping a tear from her eye as the middle of her chin began to quiver. She looked up at Troy in self-pity and remorse.

“Hullo Troy ... or should I say farewell? I really did enjoy being in the corner of your lounge room”, she said with a sniffle, “and I'm sorry if I caused you any problems.”

Mavis averted her eyes from the television Frend and avoided looking at Troy realising he was becoming mildly upset at the sight of the image of Mavis in tears on the screen.

“I'm sorry, but I must”, he said as a lump gathered in his throat.

“Oh come on now!” Mavis protested, “this is just a piece of technological junk. It's emotional output is purely fabricated. Surely it can't mean that much

to you? Can it?”

Mavis looked squarely at her image on the screen. It had started to cheer up a bit and a slight smirk rippled across her beautiful teary-eyed face.

“Troy ... would you mind talking to the Vice-President of the Frend Corporation for me?” the Frend enquired blinking her eyes innocently.

Suddenly she disappeared from the screen and was replaced by the very affable Vice-President. He had a strangely priggish expression on his face which made Troy feel a bit uncomfortable as they had nearly reached the conveyor belt.

“Hullo Mr. Day. I see we've ended up in the dismantling depot. Seems a pity that such a miracle as this model of television Frend should end up like this”, said the Vice-President warmly as he leaned forward and peered at Troy, “there's no justice in it.”

Troy raised his eyebrows briefly as he and the technician lifted the set onto the conveyor belt that was moving slowly but inextricably towards the group of dismantlers chatting away merrily as they worked.

“Well... goodbye” Troy said as he gave the Frend a final pat.

The Vice-President was still maintaining an odd smirk on his face as he suddenly snapped his fingers as if to remember something of great importance. Maybe it would be a final comment of great significance Troy thought to himself.

“Just one final question, Mr. Day ... “ he enquired with a certain air of smugness, “ ... would you be good enough to talk to this policeman here?” said the Vice-President as he vanished from the screen and was replaced by a policeman looking very serious.

“This television Frend was reported stolen and we need to take it in for questioning”, the police officer said firmly, “so would you mind taking it off this conveyor belt immediately?”

The Frend Corporation technician obeyed instantly and lifted the set back onto the trolley. Troy was speechless. Mavis stared at the ground in silence. A murmur of approval crescendoed from the mountain of television Frends. They all watched as Troy's Frend was wheeled away by the technician and through a nearby door.

Troy recognised the police officer as the one that had arrived at his home when he reported the Frend as stolen. It all seemed to make a terrible sense, a relentless, obvious, logical, conclusion. Yet only moments earlier Troy had

expected to see it taken apart and witness an absolute finality.

In a space of a few seconds Troy felt the weight of the worlds problems on his shoulders again. Not only a feeling of dread, but also a strange emotional sense of humour because as the Frend was wheeled out the door Troy noticed the beautiful young woman reappear on the screen laughing and chatting to the technician pushing her. Troy looked at Mavis standing next to him.

“Dinner?” she asked shrugging her shoulders.

There wasn't much else they could do. The television Frend was now out of Troy's hands again. It could be held in storage awaiting questioning for weeks, even months. And then there was computer law to think about.

Mavis and Troy sat in the restaurant at the pinnacle of the Frend Corporation headquarters inside the artificial Bungle alongside the picturesque Bungle Bungle Ranges with their red, yellow and brown contoured rings stretching as far as the eye could see watching a flaming red sunset.

Albert rang Troy on his mobile phone and was informed of the new turn of events as he dined under candle-light with Mavis. Albert had a lot to say about computer law.

“You know Troy, once they decide to use a computer to represent your Frend it could become a case of mind numbing complications ...” Albert advised from his vantage point in the Parliament House Tower on Black Mountain, “these law computers can ask up to sixty thousand questions a minute. The programs for their cross-examinations are so advanced that they end up finding out the truth”, Albert explained.

Troy didn't really have much to hide as he looked at Mavis across the restaurant table. He thanked Albert for his advice and put away his mobile phone.

Troy thought Mavis was so attractive in the flesh. Obviously she didn't have the encyclopaedic knowledge of the computer that worked inside the television Frend, nor did she have any of the peculiar technical malfunctions the set exhibited that placed Troy in the position he found himself. Nevertheless the dinner was perfect and Mavis invited Troy to stay the night in her apartment again in her bed.

The next morning Troy boarded a plane and flew back to Birdsville. On his return to the tent city he quickly learned that Team Providence had easily won their speed racing event and were back on top of the pecking order where they usually sat undisturbed.

What was more, as Troy stretched out in his comfortable hammock amidst the fog that had just rolled in, he was told that the Rainbow Lorikeets had collided with one of the hot air balloons which had virtually knocked them senseless not to mention the damage done to their colourful wings.

And so when he heard the sound of frantic flapping and loud squabbling above him somewhere in the dense fog he concluded that it must be the Lorikeets arriving back from their embarrassing humiliation.

They hovered down in a scattered disorientated fashion and some hit the ground quite hard as others bounced off the top of their colourful tents and fell onto the site in a dishevelled mess of confusion and chaos. The fog began to lift as the sun filtered through and the absurd weather conditions of Birdsville reflected the Lorikeets loss of face.

Troy could clearly overhear some team members abusing the captain about the unfortunate collision with the hot air balloon. The excuse given of dense heavy fog failed to appease them and soon enough there was an almighty screaming match taking place in their tent.

Troy had little sympathy for the Lorikeets and he smiled to himself as their argument turned to the time when the captain got entangled in power lines and even went back as far as the unfortunate recollection of their first captain who accidentally flew into the path of an aeroplane and got sucked through the jet engine.

It was little wonder they wallowed at the base of the pecking order Troy mused to himself. Then one of the young female Rainbow Lorikeets burst out of their tent mumbling angrily to herself. She began doing relaxation exercises on the clearing between Troy and the Lorikeets tent. A light mist drifted throughout the area and the bright sunshine gave her wings an extra glow as she inhaled and held her breath for eight seconds before exhaling in a calmer manner. Opening her eyes after six of these exercises she noticed Troy lounging curiously in his comfortable hammock and she strolled over to him.

“Hullo Troy. I was wondering if you'd ever return. Don't worry about their silly stunts”, she said gesturing towards her tent wherein the Lorikeets were still arguing, “I'm going to fly the coop and join another nest”, she said in a matter of fact way.

“What actually happened?” Troy casually enquired as he noticed her warming to the confessional nature of their conversation.

“Well we were zooming along nicely in the speed racing event in an orderly line behind our captain when suddenly, 'boyng!' he slammed into a hot

air balloon drifting in the heavy fog. It was like bouncing on a trampoline from a fifty metre drop! And we all bounced off it! Look at my wings!” the young Lorikeet complained as she spread her colourful multi-coloured wings to their full expanse revealing lacerations and holes.

Troy surveyed her wings in a sympathetic manner. Some clouds had drifted over and light rain began to fall creating a vivid rainbow from the shining sun. She smiled at Troy while her wings started a fast repetitive motion that caused her to levitate momentarily before she flew upwards seemingly following the path of the rainbow arcing into the sky.

Then the very aesthetic young Lorikeet veered away from the multi-coloured rainbow and flew away in another direction.

Chapter 20

Birdsville cleared to a bright sunny spell as Troy dozed in his hammock. Over the sound of real bird life singing and tweeting away in the trees around the place he could also catch the muffled squabbling of the Lorikeets in their tents nearby.

All the serious competition flying had been completed and the last couple of days were given over to exhibition flying and comprehensive discussions on all the events that had taken place. And no doubt the Rainbow Lorikeets would be up in front of the Tribunal for Incompetent Behaviour to explain their unfortunate collision with the hot air balloon.

These tribunals were held in the open air and usually deteriorated into derisory slanging matches but were necessary to maintain a high standard of flying safety. At any rate they broke up the endless bar-b-queues that took place and at this location everyone could be absolutely certain that the weather would be perfect because the meteorologists controlling the weather conditions had promised to finish the carnival with warm balmy weather.

Troy was also pleased to see his wife Sandra when she arrived along with their daughter Stacy and a few of her girlfriends from the drama department and it wasn't long before a few more tents went up around Troy's.

The next couple of days passed in a relaxed holiday fashion with swimming in the Diamantina River and sun bathing on its banks. Then there were the numerous bar-b-queues. There was the bar-b-que breakfast, bar-b-que morning tea, bar-b-que lunch, and bar-b-queues' afternoon tea, dinner and finally supper which had become a popular end of the day ritual. It was unanimously agreed that this location was perfect for bar-b-queues because if one started a bush fire the meteorologists could bring on the rain at a press of a button.

Stacy and her girlfriends from the drama department had started chatting up some of the Rainbow Lorikeets being tent neighbours. They had spent a lot of time licking their wounds and mending their wings and damaged pride. Any form of sympathy was welcome and so when the girls lamented the unforgiving nature of competition flying the Lorikeets lapped it up.

The Lorikeets lolled around in their deckchairs under the sun as Stacy ever so casually enquired about their possession of Troy's television Frennd. The Captain of the Lorikeets carefully glued some more feathers in place on his colourful wings and looked at Stacy with an irritated expression.

“Are you implying that we stole it from the corner of your living room?” he said in a displeased tone. The other team members looked across at their captain. Stacy shuffled her feet uncomfortably and in a chorus with her girlfriends rejected such a ludicrous idea.

“No no no no. Definitely not”, they protested together, “ but what happened? Did some pelican fly over and deliver it to you wrapped in bundling?” Stacy said seriously and quite content to duel with the Lorikeets.

“Oh alright then”, replied the Captain staring at Stacy, “it arrived here in the mail... without a senders name. This large package was delivered to us and when we opened it we discovered it was one of those television Friends with a note attached asking us to give it to Team Providence. That's all. Nothing else. “

“Hmmm... “ Stacy responded as she looked at her girlfriends. This answer correlated with the explanation given to Cathy by the young female Lorikeet who had flown the coop. Having got the information they were after Stacy and her girlfriends quickly lost interest in the conversation with the Lorikeets and wandered off chatting to themselves.

The sun was starting to set inducing a luminous red glow along the horizon for the final night of the flying fiesta. Around the Team Providence tents flaming torches and bar-b-ques flared as the small orchestrated pop band and harmonica quartet combined to give a festive atmosphere. Further over the imposing Opera House shaped tent where Team Rocks resided was crowded with flyers landing and leaving as the party rolled into the night.

Prior to the press conference various flyers carrying their torches soared high and low over the celebrations. A couple of hundred metres up in the night sky Cathy and Alexander treaded air and looked down on the spectacle below.

“I'm still not altogether satisfied about Troy's television Friend. It hasn't been dismantled yet, has it?” Cathy said to Alexander.

“I know. But what can we do? It's in the hands of the police and they have due processes of law to follow”, Alexander replied as they both started to glide down in a wide spiral towards the huge marquee where the press conference was about to commence. Two members from each of the top teams were required to present themselves to the assembled media at the conclusion of each flying carnival.

Cathy and Alexander pin-pointed the entrance of the marquee and glided in over the large press contingent and hovered momentarily before landing gracefully behind the long table covered in clusters of microphones and tape recorders. They folded in their wings and sat down next to the representatives

from Team Rocks, Laughing Kookaburras and the Rufous Whistlers. The media and onlookers became silent as the press conference began.

“Free to air live sports television here”, said the lady standing amongst the seated media as she momentarily awaited her live cross to the world sports network. She was given the go ahead and proceeded with her question.

“Congratulations Team Providence on your victory here at Birdsville, Australia. You've maintained your position on top of the pecking order of competition flying, but did you find your friends a distraction?” the reporter enquired with a smile. Alexander laughed and leaned forward to answer.

“Not at all. We enjoy their company”, Alexander replied deflecting the thrust of the question. At the back of the large marquee behind the media Troy and Sandra looked on along with Stacy and her girlfriends. Another reporter stood up with a question.

“The Ornithologist Review here”, said the young man looking around nervously, “We've all become accustomed to the top teams comprising of Team Providence and Team Rocks dominating the nest. My question is, why have the Laughing Kookaburras and Rufous Whistlers or Echongs suddenly improved their team standings?”

The various fliers glanced at each other and then looked at the two Laughing Kookaburras. Their captain with the coloration of dark brown on the back and wings with paler brown on the top of his lightly streaked head and pale blue feathers on his shoulders and with a white patch at the base of his wing quills prolonged a solemn expression as he prepared to answer.

“Our call is perhaps the most distinctive sound in the vast areas of the Australian bush. We like to make ourselves heard just before dawn, at dusk, or when the sky is overcast and cloudy and rain is imminent”, he said without humour, “so when the freedom of flight is challenged we're more than happy to fly to the edge of our territory and sing at our rivals.”

The members of the press moved around uncomfortably in their seats. Behind them the crowd of onlookers murmured amongst themselves. Troy leaned over and whispered into Sandra's ear.

“I've got a funny feeling that our flyers are becoming territorial”, Troy said in a cautionary tone.

“I know that dear”, Sandra replied gazing into her husbands eyes, “and I don't think the television media will walk away either.”

Near the front of the press conference a lady stood up wearing a leopard

skinned three piece suit with a blood red tie. She was instantly recognised by everyone present as the most ruthless predator in the media and her mere propinquity meant serious trouble for her prey. A hush settled throughout the crowded marquee.

“News of the Day here”, she said calmly, “I would like to direct my question to Team Providence.” Cathy and Alexander crossed their arms in unison and leaned back into their chairs as they warily watched the rapacious interviewer continue. “Is there any truth in the rumour that Team Providence has bungled its relationship with the television Frend?”

“Whatever would make you suggest that?” Cathy replied quickly with a quizzical expression.

“Oh come on now Cathy!” the interviewer responded angrily, “if you can't stand the heat in your lounge room you should get out.”

The atmosphere in the press conference became charged. Everyone could sense she was preparing to pounce and maul them with her line of attack. But suddenly Melissa from Team Rocks whipped out a sheet of paper.

“I would like to read a prepared statement on behalf of the flying teams present here”, Melissa said confidently as the interviewer sat down in an agitated huff. The mumbling and grumbling from the media subsided as all eyes and cameras settled on the female flier. Her timing was perfect as she paused long enough to let the anticipation build.

“We are all midway through the twenty first century. Civilization continues to progress in leaps and bounds. But the path of humanity has diverged which is why we have decided to make a statement at this press conference”, Melissa recited from the text. She took a mouthful of iced water from the glass in front of her and looked around at the crowd of media and spectators.

At the back of the marquee Stacy and her girlfriends watched anxiously. They had learned from the Rainbow Lorikeets that the most feared media predator was going to be present at the press conference and so they had written a prepared statement to thwart her predicted line of intimidatory questions. Melissa continued reading the statement.

“On the one hand we have a population that goes outdoors to enjoy life. And on the other hand we have a population that sits indoors in front of their television sets day and night. We have become increasingly concerned at the power these screens have over the indoor population”, Melissa said as she stood up to make her final point. Her emerald wings opened to their full expanse.

“The members of humanity who enjoy the great outdoors will not be intimidated or distracted by the television Friends who dictate their interests to the indoor population known as couch tomatoes!” Melissa concluded emphatically as the other flyers on either side of her also stood up and started flapping their wings. Suddenly they all took off and flew up above the astonished press and hovered over them dropping copies of the statement that fluttered down on the media contingent like confetti.

The lady in her leopard skinned three piece suit angrily brushed away the descending pieces of paper as she peered through them at the eight fliers hovering above the throng enjoying the applause from the spectators and sections of the press.

“But what about my questions you vultures!?” she screamed amidst the commotion and acclamation.

“So sorry ... but we must fly. Bye for now”, Alexander called down to her before the eight fliers soared out of the large marquee and up into the evening sky leaving only the echo of the ee-chong followed by the ringing succession of notes and the final whip-crack whistle which was the distinctive trademark call of the Rufous Whistlers team.

Stacy and her drama girlfriends looked dumbfounded as the flurry of fliers passed overhead. Troy and Sandra crowded around the girls to congratulate them on the statement they had written for the fliers to read to the press conference.

“That was really great creative writing girls!” Sandra said enthusiastically, “sensible and to the point!”

“Yeah, we know!” Stacy replied looking nonplussed, “but they changed the wording from couch potatoes to couch tomatoes!” Troy’s expression switched from adulation to mild puzzlement.

High up in the Birdsville night sky the eight fliers glided around reviewing their performance at the press conference. The two members of the Laughing Kookaburras were seriously impressed.

“Wherever did you get that statement from?” one of the Kookaburras enquired solemnly, “we all know about the outdoor, indoor thing, but couch tomatoes is a progressive description which is inspired”, he said gazing at Melissa who looked across to Cathy.

“Well, when I was trying to sign up that lovely flier who had flown the coop from the Rainbow Lorikeets she had told me in an off-hand way that she would much prefer to fly than become a couch tomato”, Cathy said as her wing

overlapped with Alexanders, “so I thought I would add it to Stacy’s statement.”

“Let's face it”, Alexander said looking across to the captain of Team Rocks, “television has been around for about one hundred years! So to upgrade the viewer from couch potato to couch tomato is more than a compliment.” Everyone agreed as they looked down on the media tent some two hundred metres below.

Inside the media tent everything was happening at once. The prepared statement by the flying teams had gone global. The instantaneous feedback from lounge rooms everywhere was a crashing wave of approval.

Chapter 21

The next day there was a mass exodus of teams and spectators returning home around Australia and the tent city soon disappeared. The trains, planes and buses were overloaded with people leaving in all directions.

After half a day of travelling Troy and Sandra were glad to be back home. Watching the flying had been great as usual but they all suffered from sore necks. Chips had arrived back safely from the Australian base on the Moon courtesy of the space-shuttle Endeavour and as everyone unpacked their suitcases and put away the tents and camping equipment in the shed he was the only one who actively pursued the whereabouts of Troy's television Frend.

Chips didn't have long to wait for an answer. Shortly after the family had sat down to have a cup of tea the door bell rang and when Troy opened the front door he found the police officer standing there holding the television Frend.

"I told you we'd return it without any fuss or bother", the officer said triumphantly as he proudly carted it down the passageway and placed it in the corner of the living-room.

"But we don't want it!" Troy protested, "don't you understand?" he continued in an exasperated tone, "we want it dismantled!"

Sandra gave the officer a nice cup of tea and a biscuit and he sat down in the comfortable armchair opposite the Frend.

"Well as you know, this television Frend of yours was taken from this living-room and I need to ask it some questions here at the scene of the crime", the police officer said clearly enjoying his tea and biscuit.

"I see ..." Troy replied gazing at the blank screen.

"Would you mind switching on please Frend?" the officer commanded. The set flickered on and the familiar face of the beautiful young woman Troy knew as Mavis filled the screen. She smiled warmly.

"Hullo Troy! It's good to back in your living-room", she said happily, "and what may I do for you officer?" she enquired giving a mock salute.

"Alright that'll be enough of that", the officer said seriously, "now I've got a question to ask you."

"Who.. me?" the Frend said looking innocently surprised.

"We all know about pieces of modern technology like you and your incredibly advanced memory banks", the officer said as he sipped on his cup of tea.

“Oh please don't...” the Frend replied blushing ever so slightly.

“Now would you good enough to tell me who removed you from this room?” the officer asked.

“Urn ... let's see ...” the Frend mumbled as she scratched her head in thought.

“Come on! Sift through your memory bank”, the officer said impatiently, “don't take all day.”

Everyone in the room leaned forward in anticipation of the answer. The Frend was clearly recalling the events she had seen in the living-room. The tiny cameras inserted all around the set could see everything. Suddenly she snapped her fingers as she recollected the occasion.

“Yes! That's right. I remember now!” the Frend said enthusiastically only to have her face cloud over in scorn, “I don't know. I couldn't see because someone placed a table-cloth over me ... again!” the Frend said disparagingly as she stared at Sandra.

Standing in the doorway between the kitchen and the living-room Sandra winced momentarily at the sudden attention being directed her way.

“Did you do that?” the police officer asked scowling at Sandra.

“Well ... yes, I suppose I did”, Sandra replied lowering her head in shame, “I mean it was only a joke. I'm sorry.”

“Right then”, the officer said as he abruptly stood up and brushed the biscuit crumbs off his trousers, “identification of the person or persons who took the television Frend is impossible to ascertain because a table-cloth placed over the set blocked its vision”, he concluded as he strolled down the passageway pursued by a flustered Troy, “and that seems to close the case. Goodbye.”

“Is that all? I could have told you about the table-cloth!” Troy protested as the officer walked out the door whistling. “What about having it dismantled?” Troy yelled out after him.

“That's not our business. Try the Frend Corporation again”, the police officer responded as he disappeared into his patrol car and hummed off down the road leaving Troy standing nonplussed at his front door.

“We may never know who took the television Frend and sent it to the Rainbow Lorikeets”, Stacy said as Troy returned to the living-room.

“Hmm... I never realised that covering a set with a table-cloth could be

such a serious offence”, Sandra pondered aloud as she poured herself another cup of tea, “I mean some people don't like being treated like a piece of furniture but this is just plain silly nonsense.”

“Next time you'll know to just put a vase of pretty flowers on the set, won't you!” Chips said wagging his finger at Sandra.

“Oh don't go on”, Troy complained as he sat down in the armchair opposite the Frend as it merrily screened colourful images of a variety of Australian native flowers accompanied by the sound of bush life ambience.

“I want to talk to you Frend”, Troy said as the flowers vanished and the beautiful young woman appeared on the screen smiling. Troy thought about Mavis and found in himself a sudden happiness at seeing her image, yet at the same time he realised he must get rid of her.

“Yes Troy. What may I do for you?” the Frend enquired politely.

“Can I speak to the Vice-President again please?” he commanded as she disappeared from the screen and was instantly replaced by the affable Vice-President with his eyebrows raised.

“Hullo there Mr. Day. You would like to have the Frend Corporation drop by and pick up your set and have it dismantled?” he enquired.

“That would be very thoughtful of you”, Troy replied.

“Well I'd say join the queue, but you've already tried that!” said the Vice-President laughing away. “No don't worry Mr. Day, that will be fine. Umm ... let's see”, he said consulting a timetable, “as you know there's a big demand to have these Frends picked up and taken away so the soonest I can help is tomorrow. That's the best we can do. Sorry.”

“Why not immediately?” Troy protested.

“Because we're BUSY !!” he snapped back angrily giving Troy a fright, “haven't you ever heard that word?”

“Okay alright that's good. Thankyou very much”, Troy replied nervously as he didn't want to offend the Frend in any way whatsoever. The Vice-President regained his composure and brushed his hands together.

“This Frend of yours will be picked up tomorrow at noon. Goodbye Mr. Day”, he said abruptly as his image disappeared and was replaced by the beautiful young woman who smiled sympathetically at Troy.

“There you have it. All fixed. Noon tomorrow and I'll be gone”, the Frend said regretfully as Troy stood up and started pacing up and down the room.

His main concern was to get through the next twenty four hours without disturbing the Frend. It didn't really matter if it was turned on or off as it still operated and the household was well aware of that. Troy stopped pacing around and looked up to realise he and the Frend were alone. He wondered what had happened to the others.

Chips had been gazing out the kitchen window when he noticed someone hiding amongst the thick gum trees that filled the back yard. He went out to investigate and to his surprise he discovered Albert hiding behind one of the trees.

“Hullo Albert ... what are you doing?” Chips enquired quizzically as Albert grabbed him and dragged him behind the tree.

“Shoosh! Just listen to me”, Albert whispered urgently. “I see the Frend is back in your living-room. There could be more trouble in store. Go and get Stacy and Sandra and bring them here. Don't tell the Frend. “

Chips went back inside and brought Sandra and Stacy outside to where Albert was hiding. They were both a bit mystified. Troy remained inside in front of the Frend chatting about things in general but nothing in particular or even mildly offensive.

Albert however had plenty of things to say to Sandra, Stacy and Chips. He had a brilliant plan. He unrolled designs, showed them time charts and produced a suitcase full of various items as he urgently whispered instructions to them all.

“Under no circumstances are you to let the Frend know what you are doing”, Albert advised them.

“What about Troy?” Sandra enquired.

“Don't tell him either. He's already been seriously compromised by the Frend...” Albert continued to whisper amidst the gum trees swaying in the late afternoon breeze.

“And Alexander?” Chips wondered.

“I'm going to the Team Providence headquarters now to brief Alexander and Cathy. They're obviously integral to this plan of action. I'll be back later to see how you're going”, Albert said as he handed Chips the suitcase which he stealthily carried into the back. shed which was also used as a workshop.

Albert left and Sandra and Stacy returned to the kitchen to prepare dinner. Stacy clearly relished her part and moved about the kitchen with theatrical flair before waltzing into the living-room where she sat down on the couch.

“You know what I'd like to see again?” she said.

“What's that?” the Frend and Troy replied in unison.

“That subterranean delight of yours... the aquarium scene!” Stacy said in a voice filled with optimism.

“Is that alright Troy?” the Frend enquired politely.

“Sure ... why not?” Troy answered in a surprised tone.

The beautiful woman disappeared from the screen and was replaced by a tranquil aquarium. Small colourful tropical fish darted around amongst the coral, strands of seaweed and a rising line of small bubbles from the miniature water wheel.

Troy and Stacy gazed at the aquarium scene for awhile. Stacy in particular seemed to be enjoying it a lot.

“Wow! Would you look at that little striped one there”, she exclaimed enthusiastically at one point, “just fantastic really.”

Troy wasn't that impressed with the aquarium but he wasn't about to offend the Frend or Stacy because he didn't want to provoke a malfunction of any description.

“Where's Chips?” Troy enquired.

“Who?” Stacy asked with a bewildered expression.

“Chips! Chips!” Troy said impatiently.

“Oh! ... Chips. He's just working on his latest school project, that's all”, Stacy replied brushing the question aside with a lightening frown.

“Not another papier-mâché planet Mars again?”, Troy asked laughing.

“No no. It's a box of reflections, or something. Nothing important”, Stacy said trying to downplay the issue. “Wow! That coral looks great!”

Dinner time arrived and so did Albert. Troy was always pleased to see one of his favourite business associates and it gave him a chance to lament the problems of his television Frend and seek reassurance over his decision to have it taken away the following day.

Troy was also surprised to see how interested Albert was in the project Chips was busily working on and Albert spent some time in the workshop helping him.

After a pleasant dinner Albert left and went home. Troy, Sandra and Stacy sat in the living-room watching the aquarium on the screen of the television

Frend. For most of the time they sat there calmly without saying anything. They enjoyed watching the aquarium.

“Hmm ... this underwater stuff is my cup of tea ... “ Stacy mentioned with feeling at one stage as the evening wore on. But the drama was all too scant and by eleven o'clock Troy looked at his watch and decided it was time for bed.

Chips had apparently finished his box of reflections project and had already gone to bed. Stacy found it difficult to tear herself away from the riveting aquarium scenes but sleep beckoned. Troy instructed the Frend to switch off and the living-room was left in darkness.

Upstairs in their double bed Troy and Sandra found it hard to go to sleep as they tossed and turned in the unrest of trying to relax and drift off into dormancy.

Troy was understandably scared that the television Frend might get up to its old tricks again so at two o'clock in the morning he decided to get a glass of water. As he passed the Frend in the darkness of the living-room it flickered on and the beautiful woman appeared wearing a nightcap and dressing gown. She yawned and looked sleepily at Troy.

“Haven't you gone to sleep yet Troy?” she enquired as her hand covered another yawn before fading from the screen as it went blank leaving the room in darkness again.

Troy drank a glass of water in the kitchen and after pacing around nervously for awhile he finally returned to his bed. Just before dawn he dozed off. The house was quiet.

At the Team Providence headquarters perched high up on a tower above the wetlands near the West Gate Bridge Alexander and Cathy awoke as the first glimmer of the morning sun broke over the horizon.

They walked briskly along the corridors to the Team Providence storeroom and took out two sets of the Icarus wings and clothing. These wings had been used some years earlier when flying teams competed in the Icarus competitions but the event had long since been abandoned on account of the sunburn factor. Nevertheless they were wings and uniforms that were resistant to extremes of heat and cold and the breathing apparatus meant that they could fly at a high altitude.

It was silence all around in the Team Providence headquarters as the rest of the team was asleep. Having put on the clothing and strapped on the Icarus wings, Alexander and Cathy quietly walked out onto the open air take off platform that had a thin layer of morning frost on it. There was no wind as they

breathed in the fresh sea air.

They began their relaxation exercises performing a variety of stretches. The city scape of Melbourne was silhouetted against the sunrise and the only sound was that of the ambience of early morning traffic. Directly below them lay the lower Yarra wetlands and marshes where the real bird life remained hidden in their nests. Further over the bay was calm.

Alexander and Cathy stood on the very edge of the platform and opened out their wide glittering wings to their fullest expanse and leaped off. They momentarily glided before their wings began to quickly swish back and forth as they soared high above the wetlands. The two fliers were virtually alone in the early morning sky as they veered off towards the eastern suburbs.

It only took about ten minutes of flying before they were hovering high above Troy's residence and with the sun just above the horizon they began to descend towards his house.

Inside Stacy had already awoken and was seated in the living-room chatting to the television Frend. It was more of a whisper because Stacy had given the Frend strict instructions not to wake the rest of the household, and especially Troy.

"You know ... I quite like having a Frend in the comer", Stacy confided in an undertone.

"Well, I must admit I've enjoyed sitting in it", the Frend replied quietly.

"It will be a pity to see you go. I personally found you very useful and informative", Stacy admitted. The beautiful woman on the screen was pleased by the compliment. Even though she was only a piece of technology she was still programmed to find fulfilment in helping people.

"Well, I can do virtually anything and that's the reason I was created by the Frend Corporation ... " she whispered in reply. Stacy caressed her chin in thought and then her eyebrows lifted.

"Do you think you can become the sun?" Stacy enquired casually.

"Oh yes, easy", the Frend answered clearly enjoying the notion.

"Really?" Stacy said in surprise, " ... and do you think you could be the sun for an hour without stopping?"

"Do you want to warm the room?" the Frend asked laughing.

"That's right. But will you?" Stacy wondered aloud.

"Of course I will", replied the beautiful young woman with a smile before

she vanished and was replaced by a really bright light that instantly flooded the living-room with sunshine.

It was a sunshine beaming out of the television set in the corner so bright that Stacy had to put on her sunglasses. The set also radiated a heat and even with sunglasses the glow was so bright that Stacy could hardly see anything else.

Chips entered the living-room shielding his eyes from the sunny glow and holding his box of reflections which he placed on the floor. He opened the lid of the box which revealed an interior lined with various mirrors.

There was a flurry of wings flapping outside as Alexander and Cathy hovered down and landed. They strolled into the living-room simultaneously folding in their glittering wings that caught the sunshine refracting it around the room.

Without even a good morning Alexander and Cathy suddenly lifted the television Frennd and placed it into the box of reflections. The bright sunshine beamed out of the top of the box until it was shut in by the lid being slammed shut. The room went instantly into near darkness as Chips nailed the lid down.

Alexander picked up the box and followed by Cathy walked outside into the backyard where the real sun was continuing to rise amidst the early morning mist. Alexander could feel the largish container he was holding begin to increase in temperature. His wings were up to the added weight and along with Cathy they took off soaring up into the clear sky.

Inside the box of reflections that contained the television Frennd it continued to shine like the sun but was reflected back on itself by the mirrors surrounding it. This feedback went on ad infinitum which caused the set to keep getting hotter and hotter, brighter and brighter.

Alexander and Cathy climbed higher and higher in their flight. The suburbs below them became smaller and smaller. At the same time the heat increased in the container Alexander was holding.

Stacy and Chips peered out of the kitchen window and could see Alexander and Cathy as just specks in the sky. Excitement was building within Stacy as she prepared for her dramatic exclamation.

It was the sort of role she really enjoyed playing as she stood alone in the living-room and breathed in deeply closing her eyes. There was a momentary silence. A quiet of dramatic intensity. Then Stacy opened her eyes and gave a loud horrifying scream of deafening proportions that echoed throughout the house.

Troy awoke with a startled shock and fell out of his bed as he scrambled to untangle the bed sheets from over his head with Sandra matching his panic.

“What the hell has happened!?” Troy yelled as he and Sandra rushed downstairs and along the passageway into the living-room where they found Stacy quivering in an almost overacted fear. She pointed her trembling finger at the corner of the room.

“It's GONE! It's gone again ... “ Stacy said falling to her knees in terror and hysteria. Troy and Sandra gazed at the empty corner of the room as Chips wandered in rubbing his eyes.

“What's happened ... ?” he enquired in a slightly stilted manner.

“The Friend has disappeared again. I feared this may happen”, Troy said mournfully. Stacy stood up in a matter of fact way.

“Oh well, now that we're all up we might as well have breakfast and get on with the day”, she said becoming remarkably composed.

“I suppose you'll go to your office early Troy ... since you're now awake?” Sandra mentioned in passing. Troy was still recovering from the realisation that the living-room corner was vacant and the Friend had vanished again.

“Umm... oh yes. That's what I'll do. I guess it might turn up in some obscure place so I won't report it as missing yet”, Troy decided as the family sat down for breakfast.

The back door flung open and the milkman walked in smiling and handed Sandra cold milk and freshly baked hot bread and eggs.

“You're all up early today!” he said cheerfully as he disappeared out the door on his way to the Jones family next door. Troy changed into his business suit and kissed Sandra, Stacy and Chips goodbye as he left for work. Since he had gotten up so early he decided to take the efficient public transport to his office and before long he was seated in a tram with his briefcase alongside.

Troy gazed out the window of the tram passed the bumper-to-bumper traffic and through the cyclone fence that surrounded the safari park next to the Melbourne Zoo. Elephants, giraffes and a few hippos lazed around in the early morning sun oblivious to the awakening city around them.

A group of school children on the tram seated near Troy noticed an unusually bright light in the sky. They pointed and giggled causing Troy to also look up into the sky.

Thousands of metres above the safari park Alexander and Cathy struggled to hold onto the container as they flew higher and higher. The sunshine beaming

out of the television Frennd was being reflected at a greater rate by the mirrors surrounding it causing the thing to become brighter and hotter.

A deep rumbling sound coupled with an increasing vibration was causing the container to split at its seams. The incredibly powerful light was glowing out through the cracks along with an unbearable heat that even Alexanders resistant uniform could hardly bear.

As the internal combustion kept increasing they knew that soon they would have to let it go as their suits and wings began to blister from the burning glow. Condensation started to boil inside Alexanders visor as he turned his face away from the searing heat and gasped for oxygen as they both flew even higher. With their gloves feeling like they were on fire they dropped the glowing container. Alexander and Cathy scattered away burnt and singed as the now luminously hot white mass of energy fell towards earth.

Inside the tram there was a shriek of horror from the passengers watching the bright glow descend.

“It's/ailing THIS way!” the commuters screamed in terror, “What is it?” they cried in fear. Troy glanced at the pandemonium inside the tram and to his added surprise he noticed Mavis standing at the other end of the tram also following the glowing ball of flame.

Suddenly the container exploded with such force that the television set was blown to pieces like an exploding star. From high above the flashpoint Alexander and Cathy watched on with interest.

“This could be how our universe was formed”, Cathy said to Alexander as they hovered around before starting their long gliding descent.

Immediately after the enormous bright explosion the passengers in the tram became silent both with relief and astonishment. One moment a glowing blow up, then nothing.

Troy and Mavis waved to each other as the tram continued on its way.

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